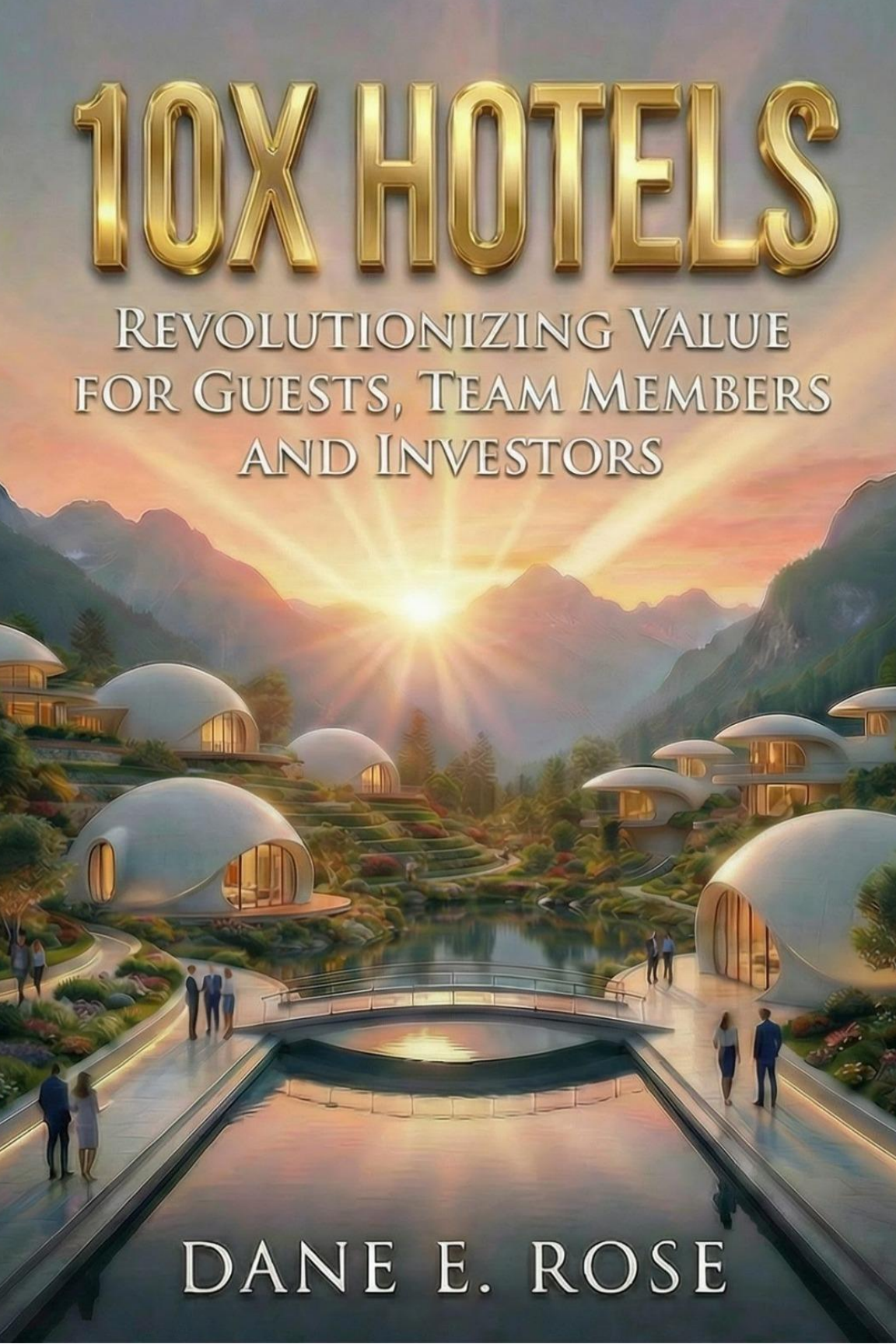
10X HOTELS

Revolutionizing Value for Guests, Team Members and Investors



DANE E. ROSE

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Chapter One

Why 10X Hotels?

If you are designing, building, or investing in a hotel, this chapter may be the most important thing you read. One hotel will always be full. Another, almost identical in amenities and price point, will struggle to fill half its rooms. The difference is not location. It is not marketing. It is not luck. Understanding why is the entire point of this chapter.

Three phenomena are making the current model of hotels obsolete. Together, they represent both the greatest crisis and the greatest opportunity in the history of hospitality.

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One: The Commoditization of Hotel Experiences

The world is drowning in a monotonous overcapacity of almost identically boring hotel experiences — and that supply is growing faster than demand. Consider what the standard hotel experience actually delivers: hunting for a taxi or shuttle at the airport while mingling with thousands of strangers; navigating flight delays; standing in busy hotel lobbies; rigid check-in and check-out time frames; fishing out physical passports for photographs; dealing with translator apps that often don't work; noisy heater and air conditioner units; figuring out the hotel lights; and frequently, the unwelcome surprise of neighborhood construction that never appeared in the brochure.

Then come the low-quality soaps. And, almost inevitably, a less-than-ideal pillow.

Then you are alone with your phone, bringing your addictions along with you — settling in, recuperating in a room that is rarely as comfortable as your own home. The world's largely empty hotel rooms tell the story plainly, as do the weary, disengaged faces of the travelers in them.

As a traveler myself, I can attest to this ambivalence. Is this really a vacation? Or just managing a series of inconveniences among strangers who have no idea what makes me comfortable? I often find myself thinking I would enjoy staying at home much more. The food is better. The sound quality is better. The TV is bigger. The shampoo is better. I can do whatever I want, whenever I want, without being disturbed. And increasingly, that is exactly what people are choosing to do — stay home. Not because they don't want to travel. Because the experience waiting for them at the other end is rarely worth the effort.

And yet the hotel model has not received a substantial upgrade in decades — while the comfort, entertainment, and convenience of staying home have never been greater. Streaming libraries that know your taste. Kitchens stocked with your food. Beds tuned to your body. For hotel developers and investors, this is not a passing complaint. It is a structural shift in consumer behavior that will only accelerate. The hotels that do not respond will not gradually decline. They will empty.

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Two: The Loneliness Epidemic

The second phenomenon runs deeper than occupancy rates, and it represents the greatest untapped opportunity in hospitality today. Western culture has been quietly fracturing. Families are more divided. Friendships are fewer and shallower. Isolation is greater than at any point in modern history. In 2023, the United States Surgeon General declared loneliness a public health epidemic, estimating that its health impacts rival those of smoking fifteen cigarettes a day. Travel, which once promised connection and adventure, has largely failed to deliver on that promise.

Many people travel alone and feel just as isolated in a new country filled with strangers as they did at home. Meanwhile, the hotels that house them are focused on throughput, not transformation — on filling rooms, not fulfilling people.

Social media has made this worse. Ordinary life — including the average hotel stay — does not provide the kind of dopamine and adrenaline that comes from scrolling TikTok. Most people understand, on some level, that spending hours a day meaninglessly scrolling has little purpose. But when they put the phone down, there is

nothing waiting to fill that gap. Certainly not the hotel minibar.

Something is missing for a great many people, and they can't quite put their finger on it. The bland professionalism of a hotel filled with strangers is not going to fill that void — and yet that is precisely what most hotels offer. Here is what is actually missing: deep, meaningful conversations. Custom peak experiences. Genuine human engagement. Warm hugs. Continuity and follow-through. The sense of being known and cared about. A feeling of love and belonging. A sense of personal growth and meaning. These are not luxuries. They are what people are quietly desperate for. And the hotel industry, almost without exception, is not providing them.

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Three: The Staff Disengagement Crisis

For hotel owners and investors, this may be the most urgent phenomenon of all — because it threatens not just revenue, but operations. The global workforce is disengaging at a historic rate, and hospitality is at the sharp end of that crisis.

The numbers are stark. Gallup's most recent State of the Global Workplace report found that 77% of employees worldwide are disengaged — costing the global economy an estimated $8.9 trillion in lost productivity. In the hospitality industry, disengagement runs even higher than the global average, with turnover rates in hotels routinely exceeding 70% annually. Staff are not quietly giving up. They are loudly leaving.

In Thailand, the pattern played out with particular clarity. During COVID, hundreds of thousands of hospitality workers returned to family farms and villages. When hotels reopened, many simply did not come back. After years of ten-hour days, rising costs of city living, and work that offered little beyond a wage, the calculation had changed. The farm was harder in some ways. But it offered autonomy, community, and a life that felt like their own.

This is not a Thai problem. It is a global one, and it will accelerate as living standards rise. Cleaning rooms for strangers at low wages. Cooking the same dishes in a loud kitchen, shift after shift, for guests who will never learn your name. As families around the world move beyond bare survival, this kind of work becomes harder to justify — and harder to staff. The best people leave first. What

remains is a workforce going through the motions, and guests who feel it.

In the coming decades, it will become impossible to hire and retain talented people for low wages and meaningless work. The hotels that survive will not be the ones that find clever ways to pay people less. They will be the ones who made the work worth doing. The talent will go where the meaning is. It always does.

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A Negative Synergy

These three phenomena are converging at precisely the wrong moment for the traditional hotel model. Guests are increasingly unsatisfied with an isolated comfortable bed. A global population is increasingly disengaged or resigning from work that lacks meaning and well-being. And as populations in many countries begin to decline while hotel construction continues, more and more properties will find themselves competing for fewer guests with less engaged teams. The math is unforgiving. The empty rooms are coming.

Each of these forces, taken alone, would demand a rethinking of the hotel model. Together, they make the current model not just inadequate — but obsolete. And for the developer, owner, or investor who understands this, the opportunity is extraordinary.

The 10x hotel is the answer to all three. It is not a passive place to sleep, eat, and move on. It is a consciously curated experience — one that many guests would rank among the most meaningful of their lives. And that distinction is not merely philosophical. It is the difference between a hotel that struggles to fill rooms and one that has a waiting list. Imagine a guest who arrives tired and skeptical, as most travelers do. Within hours, they feel something they did not expect to feel: known. Seen. At home, in a way, they rarely feel at home. That is not an accident. It is a design.

When a hotel takes the time, care, and intention to understand each guest personally — and delivers an experience they desire, value, and cannot find anywhere else in the world — the results are extraordinary. The hotel will never be empty. The staff will find their work meaningful. Investors will see strong returns. And guests will return, refer others, and carry the experience with them

long after checkout. That is not just the goal. That is the promise. The chapters that follow will show you exactly how to build it.

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Chapter Two

Low Hanging Fruit

Conversation is one of the most powerful and underused technologies for mental and emotional health and a sense of well-being. It costs nothing to produce, requires no supply chain, and burns no calories. In a world increasingly mediated by screens, it has also become genuinely rare — which makes it, in business terms, extraordinarily valuable.

Giving every team member an audiobook, a YouTube video, or a book on the art of good conversation enhances the quality of life of every team member — and that ripples

outward. Working with a happy, engaged team is a phenomenal experience for everyone involved.

I imagine a hotel or a café called The Great Conversation Café — in which every team member has one clearly stated primary goal: to have a great conversation while serving. Not to upsell. Not to turn the tables. To connect. While serving the guest drinks and food, the conversation naturally prolongs the experience beyond just eating — and invites ongoing orders. It develops the skills, the minds, and the knowledge of each staff member. And as the only place in town that actively facilitates good conversation, it would naturally become the talk of the town. Who doesn't want a great conversation?

Tips for great conversation topics become another source of revenue for the staff. It becomes one of the most sought-after places to work — which means, as a business owner, you work less to retain and train staff, and less to keep and retain customers. As a novel experience, it naturally generates free publicity. A customer who has never experienced a good conversation café will write about it in their blog, share it on social media, and the entire enterprise gets free attention — for doing nothing more

than letting human beings do what they most want to do: talk and be heard.

Round tables, thoughtfully facilitated, can let customers from around the world participate in answering open-ended questions that reveal things about themselves — creating a genuinely wonderful place to meet new people.

Surprisingly, in all of my travels around the entire world, I have never seen The Great Conversation Café — the mix-it-up-socially hotel, the meet-new-people hotel. All the things that people want to do and have no place to do — just waiting for a business owner to understand that they are not in the business of serving coffee. If they were, they have ten thousand competitors. They are in the business of providing rich, meaningful experiences. And few experiences can enrich a person's day more — at lower cost, with less infrastructure, and while burning fewer calories — than a great conversation and a new friend. The lowest-hanging fruit in hospitality has been hanging there, untouched, for decades. So why hasn't anyone picked it?

I have been to some of the finest hotels in the world — properties that cost tens of millions of dollars to construct,

that gleam with marble and imported wood — and had no one to talk to.

The staff is rushed, often having less than a few seconds per interaction, and are visibly frightened of being observed by their manager while talking to a guest. Talking — the most human of all activities — has been trained out of them. This comes from the belief that their job is serving beverages, removing dirty dishes, or seating people — rather than being present participants hosting their guests in a meaningful and welcoming experience.

In the United States, where many people are working for money rather than passion, and where wages are high, this is somewhat understandable. If someone buys a $100 dinner and the profit margin is $30, and a team member is being paid $30 an hour, an hour spent talking with a guest cuts directly into profits — even while it dramatically improves guest satisfaction and loyalty.

However, this curtailing of relationship-building in the name of efficiency and profit has been exported overseas — to places like Thailand, where the average person earns less than $30 per day. The price per meal may be similar — in some cases higher. In other words, for a team member

in Thailand to spend an hour in genuine conversation with a guest would cost the business approximately $3, not $30. The economics of human connection are entirely different here. And yet the same cold efficiency model imported from American fast-casual dining is being applied regardless. That team member would also improve their English skills — an asset to the business — while building the guest loyalty that most half-empty restaurants are desperate for.

The person who builds The Great Conversation Café — whether as a standalone business or as the beating heart of a 10x hotel — will not need to spend a dollar on advertising. Their guests will do it for them. Their staff will stay. Their tables will be full. And every morning, the team will arrive knowing that what they are about to do matters — because of the large and sincere tips, the shift in facial expression, the return of regular customers, and being sincerely thanked for listening. When people thank you sincerely every single day, that is what gives work meaning.

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Chapter Three

Field Notes: A Designer in Hell

Like most things in life, pain, discomfort, and friction turn out to be great motivators. This book is the proof: it is quite possible that without so many absurd inconveniences, I would never have written it.

I don't like spending money. My least favorite thing to do is spend money to feel worse. And as a long-term designer of inner and outer environments, as well as human experiences, I have paid close attention as I travel the world — noticing what makes me feel worse, and just as importantly, what could be done about it.

The worst part of these observations is that in many cases, the things that bothered me most are free to fix — or would have cost less money to do right the first time.

In short, I recognize that my irritations exist because either the owner, the architect, or the contractor — and ultimately all three — did not care enough about the guest experience to notice probable areas of friction, or make even a slight effort to improve it.

To give some insight into the unnecessary frictions I have encountered, I am going to unburden myself from the normal organizational structures and compartmentalization that go on in most businesses. I do this because a traveler, a guest, a tourist is not looking at a hotel as an isolated experience — but rather in the context of their entire trip.

Case in point: if a guest gets sick on the plane just as they are about to arrive in a new country at a new hotel, it doesn't matter if the hotel has gold-plated toilets. Vomiting and diarrhea will overshadow that.

This is why I believe one of the single biggest opportunities being missed by hotels is something that costs pennies and takes ten seconds: a vitamin D3, zinc,

and multivitamin pack on the pillow upon arrival. It costs pennies for a hotel to deliver this to every guest, and nobody has ever done it. If someone is feeling slightly under the weather, the last thing they want to do is hunt for a pharmacy in a foreign city. That one small act of care and thoughtfulness can transform a hotel experience. Whether it is free or available for purchase, it shows that a hotel cares.

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Field Notes: Thailand and Laos

What follows are field notes from the last month of travel across Thailand and Laos — and later, Dubai. Each entry is a real friction point. Each one was either free to fix or would have cost less to do right the first time.

I'll start with receiving an alert on my phone saying that the air quality in Bangkok was unusually poor and dangerous to my health. I wasn't aware of it, hadn't anticipated it, and it immediately raised the question of what to do about it.

There was something else I had to deal with as well. Thailand had recently changed its policy from renewable

60-day visas to requiring people to spend fewer than four months a year in Thailand, or obtain a new type of visa. The problem was that they didn't announce it anywhere I heard about. So for the first time in my life, I was harassed by Thai immigration — asked why I was spending so much time in Thailand.

What was irritating was that I couldn't get a straight answer out of them. I said: why are you bothering me for spending a lot of money in Thailand? They responded vaguely with things like: we have to keep the criminals out. I said: last year you weren't accusing me of a crime, so what does that have to do with me? Are you saying criminals should be allowed to spend four months in Thailand but not six? The whole thing made no sense.

I spent several hours getting contradictory information from ChatGPT, which first said nothing had changed, then acknowledged the policy had changed, and then had no useful guidance on what to do about it. This is worth noting: even our best available AI tools were not reliably useful in a moment of genuine travel friction. I had already had an unpleasant experience — arriving and being treated like a criminal.

Next, having arrived, I learned that my health was in danger due to poor air quality. I wasn't surprised, because Thailand is currently taxing electric vehicles with up to 200% import duty, making them cost twice as much as in the United States. By punishing rather than incentivizing electric vehicles, Thailand was effectively encouraging me to leave Bangkok.

I thought I might like to see Laos for the first time. I didn't know much about it, but landing in a relatively rural area called Luang Prabang, I did not anticipate having to deal with the air quality there either. Upon landing, the first thing I noticed was smoke in the air — if anything, it seemed worse than Bangkok. Some combination of crop burning, poorly managed diesel, barbecue, and motorcycles made for a genuinely smoky experience. I had left Bangkok to improve my air quality and stumbled into some of the worst air I had ever breathed.

What made it worse was that hotels in Laos were actually more expensive than in Thailand, and far less nice.

In the quietest hotel I could find — one with a bathtub — I was woken the next morning by multiple loud bangs as hardwood doors slammed shut around me, and

conversation from the breakfast area drifted into my room. I spoke to the general manager about small adhesive door-silencing stickers — the kind that, if placed on the door frame, would eliminate the banging entirely. He said he'd look into it and had never heard of them.

I ordered some from Lazada, because so many hotels I had visited had loud slamming doors that jolted me awake. They cost a few pennies and totally fix the problem. What amazed me was that entire hotels — with tens of thousands of guests over the years — had subjected every one of those guests to hundreds of thousands of loud door slams, without anyone spending a few pennies to silence them. This is not a resource problem. It is an attention problem. Nobody was listening.

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Traveling alone in Laos, I wanted to meet someone for dinner. That's when I discovered that you can be fined or arrested in Laos for having a romantic relationship before marriage. It was illegal to have sex before marriage, and one had to be careful not to be seen in public with someone of the opposite sex in any romantic context.

I wanted a massage at the hotel spa after dinner and was told it closed at 8 pm. No explanation. No alternative offered. The spa's hours had apparently been set by someone who had never been a guest. As a guest, one would naturally spend the day sightseeing, and by the time you returned and had dinner, it would be well past 8 pm. The ideal time for a massage is after dinner. The spa wasn't open.

Arriving in Luang Prabang by plane, I was required to pay an entry permit on arrival, payable in US dollars — something nobody had explained beforehand. The lines were confusing. People were milling about, filling out various forms and buying entrance permits. I had to go hunting for a pen, and when none could be found, I knocked on an official office door until someone produced one.

This brought into sharp relief the stark contrast between how a country can treat its visitors — like job applicants, or like guests and human beings. Imagine the first country — or hotel — that sat you down in a pleasant lounge upon arrival, offered a welcome drink and a cool towel, and had a staff member come to you personally, look at your passport, ask a few friendly questions, and answer

the ones you actually wanted answered: which neighborhoods are quiet, what to avoid at this time of year, what do first-time visitors most commonly get wrong.

Next, I discovered that Laos would not accept online payments for visas. For reasons I could not fathom, one was required to travel to the Thai embassy — which had approximately three to four hours of working hours per day — make a payment in person, then submit an online form, then travel back for an interview, then wait for the result. A journey I had not anticipated and did not enjoy.

I agreed on a price with a taxi driver, only to discover he was dropping off multiple other passengers first. We all had to cram in with several heavy bags. When we arrived near my hotel, the driver tried to save himself a few minutes by leaving me at the bottom of the street — several hundred meters from the entrance — rather than driving to the door. I had to argue about that, too.

I had checked a few hours earlier that the hotel had a room available. Upon arriving, I discovered the room was no longer available. Which meant finding a new hotel — with heavy suitcases, in the heat, while hungry. I asked the hotel if I could leave my bags there temporarily. They said

no. I asked if they had anything to eat. They pointed me to a steakhouse. When I asked if there were any vegetarian options, they said no. The hotel car wasn't available. The whole thing was the exact opposite of hospitality.

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Whenever I've tried to call a hotel — or had my assistant call — to ask whether construction is nearby or whether the air conditioner is particularly noisy, the information has been so unreliable it's not worth making the call.

On a recent visit to a hotel in Krabi, I chose one in a quiet location. The air conditioner turned out to be one of the loudest I had encountered anywhere. I asked to see other rooms in the hope that they might be quieter. The staff told me it wasn't worth looking at because the other rooms were even noisier. Having learned that hotels are unreliable with these reports, I asked to see one anyway, since I had already driven out of my way to get there and didn't want to leave without spending five minutes looking. Far from being noisier, the other available room was cheaper, nicer, and much quieter. I booked it, feeling —

once again — largely alone, fending for myself, in pursuit of nothing more than a quiet place to sleep.

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As I write this chapter, I am running a bath. As is very often the case, there is not enough truly hot water. The reason is an underpowered electric water heater — if you turn the faucet to full, the water is lukewarm. One has to reduce the flow so the heater can warm the water as it passes through. Even at half flow, it is not truly hot. I turned it down further. However, the heater had a low-flow cutoff — so while I thought I was increasing the temperature by reducing the flow, the heater switched off entirely. It took me a while to notice, by which point I had been adding cold water to my bath. Back to the drawing board: find the lowest possible flow at the highest possible temperature without triggering the cutoff. So it goes.

This is all happening at a hotel I reached after a 20-minute motorcycle ride to find their credit card terminal — because they were not equipped to take payment at the hotel itself. I am in their only available room, which has one of the noisier air conditioning units in the building. I am wearing noise-canceling headphones as I write this.

When I arrived two days ago, I was informed that the hotel had no ice. The owner thought there might be some in their house. This prompted a journey by hotel staff to the local store to buy ice, along with instructions to put the fresh coconuts in the fridge so they would be cool to drink, rather than warm from the tree.

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Kanchanaburi, Thailand — The Last Two Weeks

I started by discovering that a hotel I had stayed in before — previously well-maintained — had failed to maintain its air conditioning, resulting in a loud rattling in the room. Moving to another room, the air conditioner was even louder, and guests could be heard talking next door. The corridor outside was lined with loud external air conditioning fans. It was hard to think of anything more poorly designed from a noise perspective.

Next, a hotel where the bathtub drain didn't fit the hole, so the more water I poured in, the more it poured straight out, creating a high-pitched whine and wasting plenty of hot water. Of course, it took two or three phone calls and interruptions by technicians to eventually get a drain

stopper of the correct size. I sometimes don't know which is worse: going out of my way to find a hotel with a bathtub, only to discover the drain doesn't work, or spending an hour sorting it out once I'm there. This is not a vacation experience. This is just getting up to the basic level where plumbing functions.

I mention this because I just went through the same process here. Called reception. Explained that the bathtub drain was so poorly fitted that half an inch of water was the maximum. Multiple conversations with multiple staff members. They eventually sent down a new drain with a chain on it — a chain that had nowhere to attach in the bathtub. This prompted hotel staff to attempt to cut the chain off using their fingernails. Unsuccessfully. This, as I am trying to write a book about 10x hotels.

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Dubai — Ten Days at $600 a Night

I wish I could say that at $600 a night in Dubai, things were managed better.

Arriving by taxi with luggage, heading to dinner, I was told at the Atlantis Hotel — one of the largest lobbies in

the world — that they had no place to store luggage for guests. Anywhere in the entire hotel. When I asked to speak to a manager, I was directed to a room where several people were already in line waiting. I left my luggage and walked out.

At Nobu, looking for a snack and a drink, I found the place completely empty. When I asked to sit at a balcony table overlooking the view, I was told I couldn't sit there unless I spent a minimum of — I believe it was around $100. I explained I was just having a drink and a snack. They refused to let me sit at a balcony table in a completely empty restaurant — a restaurant I had chosen specifically for the view. It was absurd. I came away feeling that this was one of the worst hotel experiences I had ever had, and that spending $600 a night did not necessarily mean finding anyone interested in creating a great guest experience.

At an even more expensive hotel nearby — the name escapes me — I found an equally bizarre experience in their restaurant, where music from three different sources was simultaneously audible, and the three tracks did not go together. Someone had clearly spent a great deal of money to create a very ugly environment — including, I recall, a

sculpture made of rusted steel and rebar that I found genuinely unpleasant to look at. I did not eat there.

One of the best experiences I had the entire trip was a haircut and a massage from an Egyptian barber in a small shop in Dubai. It cost almost nothing and was genuinely wonderful. It was personal, attentive, and warm. It highlighted, once again, that a great experience has almost nothing to do with how much you pay — and everything to do with whether someone actually cares about the person in front of them.

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A Note on One of My Favorite Hotels in the World

The Chatrium Riverside in Bangkok — one of my favorite hotels anywhere — placed me in a room during this period that was so filled with mold and mildew on the bathroom tiles that I was genuinely worried about my health from the moment I walked in. It was the first and only time in more than ten years of staying there that this had happened. To their credit, they moved me to another room within minutes. But it confounds me that my favorite hotel in the world — and a hotel with no shortage of staff

— had allowed a room to reach that state without anyone noticing the smell of mold and mildew. There is massive room for improved attention to detail at all levels.

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I am closing this chapter, having covered roughly 30% of the hotel frustrations I encountered in recent months.

I will mention one more pattern, repeated at multiple hotels in the Maldives and elsewhere. I arrive for a nap and put up the Do Not Disturb sign. The phone next to the bed rings at an intense volume and keeps ringing. Irritated, I pick up. The reason they're calling, they explain, is that they have laundry to deliver and noticed the Do Not Disturb sign — so they decided to call me on the phone instead of knocking. I explained that the reason I put the Do Not Disturb sign up was that I did not want to be disturbed — and that being woken by a telephone call about non-urgent laundry was, in fact, being disturbed. I hung up.

The same thing happened at my hotel in Laos. Laundry. Phone call. Do Not Disturb sign ignored.

I have subsequently taken to unplugging the hotel phone as standard policy. It is not worth getting upset about. It is clear that a percentage of hotel staff around the world genuinely believe that calling guests by phone — rather than simply not disturbing them — is the appropriate response to a Do Not Disturb sign.

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I want to close this chapter by saying that I believe most hotels think they are in the business of providing a comfortable place to sleep and following standard protocols. This is wrong. No customer cares about standard protocols. Most people have many preferences and values — and thousands of hotels to choose from. The real business a hotel is in is providing rich, meaningful experiences that are genuinely worth leaving home for. Everything in this chapter was a failure to understand that. And every single one of those failures was fixable.

I believe the minority of hotels that adopt this focus and mission can and will succeed on multiple levels — and will earn the loyalty of their guests. Not because guests are virtuous, but because most of the hotels in the world are,

quite simply, not doing it. For those who do, there will be no competition worth worrying about.

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Chapter Four

The Five Senses

The finest hotel experience is not built by adding more. It is built by removing what is wrong. Understanding why requires understanding one uncomfortable truth about the human brain.

Pain, fear, and discomfort are always five times louder than any sense of pleasure and well-being. This is neurologically programmed and difficult to override. The reptilian brain prioritizes any possible threat or challenge, and as a result, relatively minor irritations tend to dominate the human experience. One consequence of this is what might be called the lowest common denominator effect.

Consider a slice of pizza. The cheese is good, the tomatoes are good, the dough is nice — and then you taste it, and it is incredibly salty. Every other quality disappears. All attention goes to the salt. Or consider sitting in a beautiful restaurant with wonderful smells and warm ambiance — and somebody scrapes their nails on a blackboard. The food, the décor, the candlelight: gone. All attention goes to that single discordant sound.

In practical terms, what this means is that a hotel guest's experience sinks to its lowest common denominator. If you have spent $10 million on the lobby, but the neighbor is burning plastic and that acrid smell is drifting through the front door, nobody enjoys the Italian marble. Nobody notices the natural silk uniforms. Everyone is focused on the smell. That one unattended sensory failure wastes every dollar invested in every other part of the experience.

I see this in hotel lobbies constantly. The smell may be neutral. The visual architecture is tasteful. There is nothing to taste. The textures of the chairs are often unremarkable. But the sound of loud walkie-talkies, noisy air conditioning, and rattling luggage carts echoing through a space with no sound buffering is so obnoxious and unrelaxing that I simply want to leave. Someone has spent millions of dollars

on that lobby. Four of the five senses are adequately served. One is not. And that one rules everything. I would enjoy that lobby five times more if the walkie-talkies were silenced, some carpet absorbed the echo, and the luggage carts had air in their tires. Total cost: almost nothing.

As far as I am concerned, that hotel could have saved 50% of the money spent on décor. Something simple, rustic, and peaceful — with good sound — would be more enjoyable.

The first principle to guide action in this territory is: reduce pain and discomfort before you do anything else. The second is to look for balance.

You have five senses. How does your environment serve each one? Do you have uncomfortable bedding but fine art? Amazing food with a nauseating soundtrack? Rate your environment honestly on each of the five senses — out of ten. Add up the scores. Then focus every available resource on whichever sense scores lowest. That is where you will find your highest return on investment. Not in the next marble countertop. In the thing your guests are quietly suffering through. Fix the weakest sense first. The return will surprise you.

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Chapter Five

The Power of Presence

This chapter explores the value and art of creating presence — in both team and guests — one of the most valuable experiences on earth that also happens to be free.

Attuned attention is one of the most valuable things on earth — and it may be the only thing money cannot buy. A billionaire can point to almost any company, any stock, any item, any piece of art, and say: I want that. And in most cases, someone will get it for them. But presence cannot be purchased, delegated, or faked for long. It is a gift. It is rare. And it is always medicinal.

A person who is centered, aware, attuned, and responsive — who makes you feel genuinely seen — is one of the most satisfying human experiences available. And it costs nothing to produce and nothing to deliver. It is also far more impactful than most hotel investments: bring a genuine presence to an interaction, and you will typically double the enjoyment of both the guest and the team member providing it.

Presence is not a personality trait. It is a practice. And the science behind that practice has never been more robust.

A 2011 Harvard study found that just eight weeks of mindfulness practice produced visible changes in the brain — increasing grey matter density in regions associated with self-awareness and compassion, while reducing activity in the amygdala, the brain's threat-detection center. In other words, meditation makes people calmer, more aware, and more genuinely present with others.

For a hotel, this is not a philosophical observation. It is an operational one. A staff member who meditates regularly is neurologically better equipped to be present with a guest — to listen without distraction, to respond

without reactivity, to notice what is needed before being asked. The return on a fifteen-minute morning meditation practice for every team member is not measurable in any conventional hospitality metric. But guests feel it instantly.

Hotels and retreat centers that have built daily meditation and yoga into their rhythm — from the Amangiri in Utah to the Como Shambhala in Bali — report not only higher guest satisfaction but markedly lower staff turnover. Three yoga sessions offered daily, morning, midday, and evening, are not simply wellness programming. They are an invitation to every guest and every staff member to slow down and arrive fully in the present moment. Friends stay where they feel well.

This is particularly important when something goes wrong. Smiling warmly while telling a guest there is no way to bring them a glass of cold water — something I have actually been told by hotel staff during check-in, believe it or not — is not fun to hear. But when you empower your staff to truly listen and respond — to be present rather than protocol-driven — the results are extraordinary. A guest who feels heard will forgive almost anything. A guest who feels ignored will remember it forever.

The presence of a team member is powerful. But presence can also be designed into the fabric of a hotel itself — through ritual, space, and the quiet architecture of meaning.

Ritual: The Language of Presence

One of the simplest and most profound rituals available to any hotel is the blessing at meals. Rather than imposing a formal or religious blessing, inviting guests to volunteer one — spontaneously, in their own words — creates a moment of genuine human warmth shared at the table. It is not inconceivable that the highlight of an entire trip could be a stranger standing up and offering something heartfelt to fifty friends they met three days ago.

Chanting carries similar power. Used in Buddhist temples across Thailand, Bali, and Myanmar — in Gregorian monasteries, in Sufi lodges, in the kirtan traditions of India — chanting is one of the oldest technologies for inducing collective presence. The vibration of shared sound, sustained together, produces measurable reductions in cortisol and measurable increases in oxytocin — the bonding hormone. A hotel that marks the minute of sunrise and sunset with a brief communal

chant — a single Om held together, then released into silence — does something remarkable. It brings an entire group into the present moment simultaneously, bonding them around something beyond words. Guests who have never chanted in their lives often find themselves moved to tears. It costs nothing. It takes sixty seconds. And it is unforgettable.

A well-placed shrine — a small altar with candles, flowers, a bowl of water, an image or object of beauty — simply says: this is a space where something beyond the ordinary is happening. I always enjoy my visits to Thai temples — both for their beauty and for the ritual of lighting incense and bowing to something larger than myself. Shrines in a 10x hotel need not be religious. They can honor great human beings and their work, qualities of character, or states of being — a Shrine of Peace, a Shrine of Courage, a small altar dedicated to the life and work of Elisabeth Kübler-Ross and her profound reckoning with death and dying. Each one invites a guest to pause, to reflect, and to leave slightly different from how they arrived.

Every 10x hotel should have a place of silence — a room or a corner or a garden designated, clearly and

without apology, as a space for quiet. No music. No television. No conversation above a whisper. In a world of relentless noise and stimulation, silence has become one of the rarest and most sought-after experiences on earth. The guests who find it will return for it. The staff who tend it will be changed by it.

More and more friends want to be near others without needing to perform for them. Research in nervous system regulation confirms what people intuitively know: the simple physical proximity of calm, present human bodies is itself regulating and restorative. A quiet common room — where guests may read, knit, paint, meditate, or simply sit — with a single rule posted gently at the door: no speaking. No screens. No noise. This is not antisocial. It is one of the most social things a hotel can offer.

Architecting Gratitude

If presence is the practice, gratitude is its natural fruit.

The Big Book of Gratitude in the hotel lobby is exactly what it sounds like — a large, beautiful journal, set on a dedicated table with good pens, in which any guest may write something they are grateful for. Not a review. Not a

suggestion. Simply a moment of acknowledgment, offered freely, to be read by whoever comes next. Hotels that have introduced versions of this report that guests spend far longer in the lobby than they otherwise would — reading, writing, and feeling the accumulated warmth of hundreds of strangers who passed through before them. It costs almost nothing. It creates a living record of human experience that no TripAdvisor page can replicate.

Video notes from guests for other guests to take this further. A simple tablet or small camera station — warm, well-lit, inviting — where departing guests can leave a thirty-second message for whoever stays in their room next. What was wonderful. What they discovered nearby. What they wish they had known on arrival. These notes, played on the room television as a welcome on arrival, do something remarkable: they make the guest feel they are arriving in a community, not a vacancy. The room was loved before they arrived. Someone thought of them before they got there.

Anonymous notes are perhaps the most quietly radical of all. Small cards, available at reception and throughout the hotel, on which any guest may write anything — a compliment, a poem, an observation, a question — and

leave for any other guest or staff member. No names required. No context needed. Just the simple, ancient pleasure of leaving something kind for a stranger. Hotels that have introduced this practice find that the notes accumulate in unexpected places — tucked under doors, left on breakfast tables, pinned near the shrine. They become part of the texture of the place. They make guests feel that the hotel is alive.

The hotel that understands this — and builds it in, quietly and without pretension — will not need to compete on price, location, or thread count. It will compete on the felt sense that something real happened here. That two human beings were seen. The precedents for this are ancient and global: the monasteries of Mount Athos in Greece, operating continuously since the tenth century and perpetually full; Thich Nhat Hanh's Plum Village in France, built entirely around mindful presence and communal living; the Esalen Institute in California, where conversation, ritual, and presence have been the primary product since 1962. None of them advertise. All of them have waiting lists.

That is what presence, fully realized, makes possible. And it begins with a staff member who actually looks up when a guest walks in.

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Chapter Six

First Time Memories

The brain processes first experiences differently — in a dedicated region called the hippocampus, with heightened attention and deeper encoding. Emotionally charged first experiences also activate the amygdala, which is why experiences that make us feel something are remembered far more vividly and durably than neutral ones. The memory is then consolidated for long-term storage in the neocortex. As a result, a first experience always stands out. And it continues to stand out for as long as it remains the only experience of its kind.

The implications of this principle are profound. People are having more experiences, and more saturation and overload of experience, than at almost any other point in human history — every single day. And that drowns out all ordinary experience faster than it ever has — making ordinary a business death sentence.

That means you have two choices. You can spend large amounts of money to continually remind people who you are. Or you can do something — anything at all — that someone has never experienced before. That experience will stand out and be remembered.

Nobody goes home and tells their friends that they stayed at a hotel and it had pillows. The pillows could be exceptional. It simply doesn't matter — because exceptional ordinary is still ordinary. Nobody says their hotel room had a door, even if it was the nicest door in the world. Because it's ordinary. But if you are the only hotel in the world to have ever placed a small cocktail of vitamins, zinc, and D3 on the pillow upon arrival, not only will your guest remember it, but they will photograph it, write about it, and tell everyone they know. They will mention it in their review, because it stands out from the ordinary.

The beauty of this principle is that being one of a kind in the world does not need to be difficult or expensive. Let me give you a few examples — beginning with the moment a guest walks through the door, which is where most hotels squander their best opportunity.

I have been to hundreds of hotels with spas, and I have even seen some of them offering free 15-minute sessions. But I have never tried one. I don't know if I'll like the masseur. I don't know if it's worth the bother of finding out where the spa is and making an appointment for a 15-minute massage. But what about this: you walk through the entrance, and rather than joining a check-in queue, a staff member guides you to a comfortable chair and asks: while you wait, would you like a seven-minute massage? Shoulders, head, hands, or feet — your choice. I have never experienced it. But even if the massage wasn't very good, I would remember it. And it would be fantastic for business.

First, guests wouldn't resent having flown halfway around the world only to stand in a hotel lobby and wait. Second, people don't want a massage — they want a feeling. And some masseurs can give it to them, and some can't. They don't know, and they don't want to pay and book an appointment to find out. With a free seven-minute

massage, a guest can get a visceral experience of what it feels like to work with a particular practitioner — and is then in a position to book a full appointment with confidence. Most importantly, it has never been done before. Tens of thousands of hotel lobbies around the world have the same routine playing out — luggage, passports, waiting. The best hotels immediately offer a cool scented towel and a welcome drink. Many of those drinks are too sweet or too cheap, but the gesture still makes an impact. A five to seven-minute massage while you wait — now that is something nobody has ever experienced. And the reality is that the spa would make more money doing this than not, because it starts with a generous act, builds confidence — particularly if the practitioner is skilled — and establishes a personal relationship, which is something people miss deeply, particularly when traveling alone.

Or consider this: you arrive, and while you wait, a sketch artist sitting quietly in the corner begins drawing your portrait. You notice. You watch. When check-in is complete, they hand it to you — you may buy the original, or simply take a photograph of it and walk away with something you will keep forever. For free. Have you ever experienced that in a hotel lobby? Neither have I. But the

truth is, as long as a business is going to ask its guests to wait in a room, turning that waiting into a novel experience is part of standing out — and again falls into the category of free publicity.

If you were reading a hundred reviews before choosing your hotel, and only one of them said: in addition to my cool towel and welcome drink, I received a seven-minute massage — or: my portrait was drawn, and here is the digital photograph — I know which hotel I would book.

First Times Beyond the Lobby

The principle of novelty does not end at check-in. It can be woven into every moment of the stay — and the most powerful applications are often the simplest. Here are five more examples, none of which I have ever encountered in any hotel anywhere in the world.

Wish upon a star. Whether through a rooftop telescope on a clear night, or a simulation dome fed by a live camera trained on a real sky somewhere in nature, guests are invited to choose a star, name it, and have their photograph taken — superimposed on their view of the night sky, a halo around their star, its new name printed alongside. The

image is ready for social media within minutes. Cities, cloudy nights, no problem — the dome brings the sky to them regardless. The experience is intimate, romantic, and entirely shareable. No other hotel offered it.

That experience lives in the body as much as the mind — which is exactly where the most durable memories are made. The next example goes further, turning a guest into a creator rather than a recipient.

Cook your dish. Feed the world. Guests are invited to cook one dish — anything from their own tradition, their grandmother's recipe, something they invented — in the hotel kitchen, guided by a chef. The session is filmed and edited into a short, warm video for the hotel's YouTube channel, where past guests can watch, remember, and feel the pull to return. The recipe joins a growing online cookbook, and a beautiful print-on-demand version — available only to guests — can be ordered and delivered anywhere in the world. The hotel's YouTube channel becomes a living archive of the people who passed through, the food they loved, and the stories behind it.

What these experiences share is active participation — the guest is not watching, they are doing. The darkness

dinner takes that one step further by removing the one sense we rely on most.

Dinner in the dark. For guests staying seven nights or more, once during their stay, the hotel quietly arranges a surprise dinner — allergies and strong dislikes already noted in the hotel app at check-in. The room is completely dark. One or two team members serve and, if the guest wishes, gently feed them. With sight removed, every other sense sharpens. Flavors land differently. The conversation changes. Guests who have experienced it describe it as one of the most unusual and memorable meals of their lives. It costs almost nothing beyond the food itself. It requires only darkness, trust, and care.

A letter to your future self. At a dedicated writing desk — gold-embossed royal stationery, a wax seal, a good pen — guests write a letter to themselves, to be posted exactly one year later. The hotel keeps the address and sends it without fail. Twelve months on, an envelope arrives bearing the hotel's crest. Inside: the words of someone the guest used to be, written in a place that mattered to them. The cost is postage. The return is extraordinary.

The letter works because it connects the present self to the future self — a rare and powerful emotional bridge. The wall of blessings works for the opposite reason: it asks nothing of the guest at all.

The wall of blessings. In a softly lit corridor — dim, quiet, set apart from the bustle of the hotel — twenty-one small speakers are set into the wall at ear height, each playing a different track of blessings on quiet, continuous repeat. Guests slow down as they pass. Some stop. Some press their ear gently to a speaker and stand there for a moment, receiving something they didn't know they needed. The blessings come from different traditions, different languages, different voices. Nobody designed this corridor for Instagram. But guests photograph it anyway.

Just as the artist makes more money doing portraits in a hotel lobby than waiting for customers in an art store, the spa makes more money giving seven-minute tasters than sitting in an empty treatment room. These simple gestures generate ten to a hundred times more word-of-mouth than any advertising campaign — at no additional cost. But more than that, they are signals. They tell a guest, from the very first moment, that this place is different. That someone thought about them before they arrived. That this

is not going to be ordinary. And once a guest believes that — truly believes it — the entire stay is colored positively by that belief.

There are literally hundreds of experiences like these — unique, high-value, low-cost — waiting to be discovered and offered. The ones that are right for your hotel will depend on your own passions as a host and the particular gifts of your situation. The principle, however, is universal: do one thing nobody has ever done before, do it with genuine care, and your guests will never forget you.

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Chapter Seven

The Hotel as World

When Disneyland opened on July 17, 1955, Walt Disney did something that had never been done before: he built a world. Not a park, not an attraction — a complete, immersive world with its own logic, its own aesthetic, and its own emotional atmosphere. People didn't just visit Disneyland. They entered it.

Today, almost everyone is bombarded with gadgets, technology, and stimulation at a level that would have been unimaginable in 1955. Digital detox has become a genuine aspiration. The world's most famous attractions have been viewed billions of times on YouTube — without traffic,

without tuk-tuk smoke, without the heat, without the queue. The bar for what makes something genuinely worth leaving home for has never been higher. And most hotels are nowhere near it.

So what is actually missing? What does almost nobody have in their daily life — not in their city, not at the tourist site, not in the average hotel?

Real interactions with slow, present people — off their phones. A three-hour conversation with someone they just met. Complete and utter silence. A chance to play with a dog. Deep eye contact without agenda or awkwardness.

I haven't petted a friendly dog in over a month — despite traveling through several countries and staying in multiple fine hotels that charged handsomely for the privilege of not providing one. It is safe to say that spending time with a friendly dog would have stood out far more than the paint colors the hotel designer agonized over, or the many other hotel features I didn't even know existed.

In addition to the dozens of experiences people know they want and don't have, there are also hundreds of experiences people have never had and haven't even considered wanting.

The question every hotel developer should be asking is this: rather than designing a sleeping place from which guests venture out into a busy, traffic-filled world, why not create a world so rich with unique and satisfying experiences that exploring the hotel world is the most exciting experience around?

What a wonderful day it is to have never had to get into or out of a vehicle. What a wonderful day to have a conversation that didn't require going somewhere to meet someone.

What a pleasant surprise to arrive on a keto diet and find that the hotel already knows — and has arranged accordingly. Not because you filled out a form at check-in. Because the hotel app asked you before you arrived, and someone actually read the answer. How liberating not to think about meal times at all, because three buffets a day or a custom caterer is always on hand, always adapted, always personal.

Better yet — imagine brainstorming sessions designed to create a peak experience, with multiple guests collaborating together, with staff, or with other guests who share similar interests.

What the World Looks Like

A world is not built from a single extraordinary moment. It is built from the accumulated texture of a day well spent — without ever needing to leave.

Consider what a single day might hold. A morning yoga session followed by a seven-minute shoulder massage while the chef prepares breakfast. A buffet that already knows you are keto, or vegetarian, or that you hate cilantro — because someone read the answer you gave before you arrived. A great conversation over coffee with a staff member who has been trained to be genuinely present, genuinely curious, and genuinely interested in you.

After breakfast, a flower arranging class at a long table with six strangers who are, by lunch, no longer strangers. A sketch of your face, drawn while you waited, now propped on your windowsill. The smell of the essential oil sachet you chose yourself drifts from your pillow.

In the afternoon, silence. Real silence, in a room designed for it. Or the wall of blessings in the corridor, which you have now visited three times because each speaker offers something different. Or a letter written to

yourself at a gold-embossed desk, sealed in wax, already on its way to your future.

At sunset, the Om rises from the garden. You join it, or you simply listen from your balcony. Either way, you feel it.

Dinner in the dark. A blessing volunteered by a retired teacher from New Zealand who makes everyone laugh and then, unexpectedly, cry.

A note slipped under your door from a guest you met at breakfast — a poem, a recommendation, a simple thank you for the conversation.

This is not a hotel. This is a world. And the mall down the road, the tourist temple, the crowded restaurant with the thirty-minute wait — none of them come close.

The more time people spend together in quality, slow, and creative interactions, the more friendships are likely to form — both with the staff and with other guests. And what better reason to return to a hotel than to spend time with the friends you made there?

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Chapter Eight

Personal Hosting

We come now to one of the most entrenched structures in the hotel industry: specialized labor.

A team of house cleaners does the house cleaning. Chefs who have never met you rotate in and out and prepare your dinner. The menu is standard for all guests. Nobody knows your allergies unless you communicate them each time to the person taking your order. And absolutely no one in the hotel knows your dreams, your values, why you came on the trip, what would make it fantastic, or what would ruin it for you. It is a don't ask, don't tell world. Everyone is doing their job as they are

supposed to — and it is not particularly personal. Of course, people know your name on the first day and by the third. The problem is that it is all they know.

What if this template of anonymous specialization were flipped on its head?

From the moment a guest signs into the hotel app, they are assigned a specific host or hostess — ideally matched, where possible, on compatible interests. The host's job is to facilitate a 10x experience for that guest. How? By being their sole contact person from start to finish, navigating and advocating within the hotel's infrastructure to create the best possible experience.

Their role begins before the guest arrives — reading the pre-arrival questionnaire, noting the preferences, thinking about what this particular person might love. It continues at the airport, on the drive to the hotel, in the choice of room, in the unpacking, the tour, the dinner reservation, and the morning schedule. They assist with luggage. They clean the room. They participate in some of the activities alongside the guest. They are, in the truest sense of the word, a host. A personally attuned host who covers perhaps 50% of the roles normally assigned to specialists

— but who also does something more. Their constant goal is to be present and attuned to one guest.

In practice, this might look like this: on the second morning, the host remembers that the guest mentioned wanting to try a local fruit they had never tasted. It appears on the breakfast tray without a word. That evening, the guest had said in passing that they were feeling slightly overwhelmed. The host quietly arranges for an hour of silence in the garden rather than the group activity originally planned. The host was simply paying attention — and that attention, compounded over several days, becomes one of the most memorable experiences of the guest's life.

When this is done well, it is an extraordinary experience for both the host and the guest. It allows time for genuine conversation, for discovery, for collaboration. It also creates a secure and trusting relationship that minimizes friction throughout the entire stay.

The host's role can also extend to matchmaking between guests. If Alice, hosting for John, discovers that he is writing a book on astronomy and mentions it at the morning staff meeting, and Janice mentions that her guest

Peter has spent thirty years as an astrophysicist, a dinner introduction almost arranges itself. The hotel didn't manufacture that connection. It simply paid attention. Similarly, two solo travelers with compatible interests can be gently assisted in spending some time together. The goal is always the same: to attune to the guest and curate their unique experience, with one sole advocate throughout.

The system works best as three layers. First, when a guest books, they receive a small selection of host profiles — a photo, a short bio, two or three sentences about their passions — and may request a specific host or accept an assigned match based on compatible interests. Second, before arrival, host and guest share a brief video chat — giving both a chance to establish rapport before the guest boards the plane, and giving the host a head start on understanding what this particular person needs. Third, every host has a designated backup — available for days off and for the rare case where a reassignment is needed. In the rare case where a host and guest simply do not connect, a graceful reassignment to the backup host — handled warmly and without drama — ensures the guest's experience is never compromised by a single pairing.

Even better would be a restructuring of the normal work schedule so that a host immerses themselves fully with a particular guest and then takes a day or two off when that guest checks out — before beginning with the next. Many hotels currently rotate their team arbitrarily between night and day shifts based on hotel schedules. In this model, the host's schedule is attuned to the guest's — knowing in advance when the guest generally likes to sleep and wake, and communicating the night before whether they would like breakfast in bed, and exactly what they would like for breakfast the next morning.

This model does not necessarily increase hotel costs. What it does is redirect existing labor toward a single point of relationship rather than spreading it across anonymous functions. The result is 300% more perceived value for the guest — without a corresponding increase in cost to the hotel. It is a genuine win-win, particularly when a tipping culture allows guests to express appreciation to their host throughout the stay, which, depending on the country, could effectively double the host's salary. This also opens the possibility of hosts working as independent contractors, showing up during busy seasons to make a good income, with some choosing to take only one or two

engagements a month while others prefer regular full-time work.

The entire focus remains on the quality of the relationship between the host and the guest. Everything else — the room, the food, the facilities — is the stage. The relationship is the performance. And a performance that is personal, attentive, and genuinely caring is one that guests will travel across the world to experience again.

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Chapter Nine

Creating a 10X Location

In the case of existing hotels, there are numerous ways to upgrade them toward a 10x experience. Focusing on the cultural dimension, there is simply nothing more important than the quality and depth of interaction between people. However, when considering a new 10x hotel or resort built from the ground up, location is among the most important factors.

Given the goal of a 10x experience for guests, and the fact that 95% of any surrounding area will offer a considerably lower quality of experience, the operating paradigm is one of creating an insulated cocoon — a place

in which people can have a better experience at the hotel than anywhere else. This is profoundly liberating when it comes to location.

When a hotel relies on nearby attractions to provide value and drive bookings, the hotel itself becomes secondary. Guests are staying in order to visit other places, which means the hotel's value is borrowed rather than created. This limits location to proximity, and proximity to popular attractions means expensive real estate. That model can easily multiply the cost of land tenfold, without adding a single dollar of value to the guest's experience at the hotel itself.

When the value of a 10x hotel comes from the people, the activities, and the world within its boundaries, the hotel can be located anywhere on earth.

Consider Two Scenarios:

In Scenario A, a guest comes to see New York City — Times Square, the Brooklyn Bridge, and the landmarks. The hotel must be closed. That proximity could cost millions of dollars in real estate alone. Add to that the traffic, noise, and sensory overload of a dense urban environment, and the bureaucracy of urban construction,

and it becomes very difficult to create a cost-effective 10x experience under those conditions.

In Scenario B, one could buy a fifty-acre farm plot with a natural river and native forest in Costa Rica for $200,000, where the air smells of rain and earth, the forest canopy filters the afternoon light, and the river can be heard from the path. Rather than compressing bedrooms into uncomfortable rooms and businesses into tight corridors, one can create an off-grid campus with silence, clean air, privacy, abundant space for exercise in nature, and the ability to expand facilities gradually over time with minimal stress.

The cost is ten times lower. The air quality, the soundscape, the aesthetics — each is ten times higher. Sight and smell are abundantly rewarded. Touch and taste are equally served. And because a genuine 10x experience is straightforward to market and simple to deliver on, this creates a true win-win: lower cost for the guest, higher profit for the hotel.

Team members in a place like Costa Rica cost approximately five times less than in New York City, and carefully chosen, they may be far more naturally suited to

creating meaningful 10x experiences. Animals can be integrated far more easily in a rural setting, and for many guests, they represent thirty percent of the perceived value of a stay. A multi-acre property creates natural opportunities for walking and cycling trails, reducing the need for a gym. Health can be further enhanced with on-site organic food grown within the property itself.

The Ideal Qualities of a 10x Location

Every quality that follows shares one characteristic: nature provides it for free. The first and most important is natural beauty itself — and if a piece of land already looks more beautiful than most manicured gardens, no money needs to be spent creating that beauty. It is already there. Care must simply be taken to build paths that preserve rather than diminish it.

As a walking and cycling campus, all gas-powered vehicles can be eliminated from the property entirely. Guests arrive and leave their cars at the entrance. From that moment on, everything within the property is electric and human-scaled. This saves money on landscaping while creating a genuinely distinctive experience — because no two pieces of nature are alike.

Lush tropical environments are among the most relaxing and enjoyable for swimming, wandering, and simply being still.

There is tremendous value in owning a piece of land large enough or remote enough to be genuinely silent at night — and to still enjoy a full canopy of stars. A brilliant starry night is among the most beautiful sights available to a human being, and if the land is chosen carefully, it is completely free.

A natural river running through or bordering the property is a significant asset — the sound of moving water alone is worth more than most amenities, and it costs nothing to choose land that already has one. Beautiful old trees add enormous character and presence, and are frequently included in natural plots of land at no premium. A natural lake is ideal. In tropical areas with high rainfall, or on land adjacent to a river, a lake can be constructed simply by digging below the water table — lined with sand, fed by rain, it becomes a place people return to every day without being asked. Such a lake offers chemical-free swimming, natural beauty, and a centerpiece for the property that costs a fraction of a constructed pool.

Diverse Microclimates

Because the goal is to create unique and curated value, being in a remote area also allows the property to offer experiences that would be impossible in an urban setting.

A portion of the property — say, three acres of a twenty-acre forest — could be designated as clothing-optional. This costs nothing to provide and creates genuine additional value for a percentage of guests who are interested in exploring a naturist experience. Those guests simply walk through a gate. Everyone else remains on the other side of it. No announcement, no awkwardness, no obligation — just the presence of a choice, freely available to those who want it.

Areas of the property can similarly be designated as silent zones — spaces where no verbal communication takes place, and all interaction happens by message. This allows guests who want stillness to be among others without noise. In this way, a single property can serve a remarkable range of temperaments and preferences simultaneously.

Because a twenty-acre property in the right location can be purchased for less money than a thousand-square-foot

apartment in a dense city, all of these diverse and rich experiences actually save the owner and the guest money rather than costing them. The senses — sight, sound, touch, smell, and taste — are abundantly fulfilled by a rich tropical farm and forest at a fraction of the cost of urban luxury. The architecture can then be simple and elegant, and all remaining focus goes to the thing that matters most: the interactions between people.

The Arrival Experience

Given that a genuinely 10x location is often remote, the drive from an international airport could appear to be a liability. It need not be.

Each guest's personal host meets them at the airport — by name, with help for luggage, a prepared welcome, and a spacious, comfortable electric SUV stocked with some of their favorite snacks, already known from the pre-arrival questionnaire. The host either accompanies them on the drive or has a reclining seat and an eye mask ready if the guest prefers to rest.

The ability to talk on the drive — to genuinely get to know one another — transforms the journey into a bonding experience rather than a wasted hour. By the time

the guest arrives at the property, the host already knows what they would like to do that day and has called ahead so that things are ready. Passport details can be photographed during the drive, and check-in can be completed entirely in the vehicle, so that the guest steps out and walks directly to their room, regardless of the time of arrival.

Even a two-hour drive, handled this way, can be a more enjoyable experience than the standard process of an uncomfortable taxi to an anonymous hotel and a queue at a front desk. And it costs the hotel far less than paying a premium for an expensive piece of city real estate. The remoteness that once seemed like a disadvantage turns out to be the point. Distance from the ordinary world is not a problem to be solved — it is the first thing the hotel sells.

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Chapter Ten

The Power of Residencies

The guest who arrives for a week and leaves wishing they never had to — that guest can be found in many of the finest hotels in the world. The difference at a 10x hotel is that the feeling is so consistent and so much stronger that it stops being a passing thought and becomes a genuine question: what would it take to stay?

This desire is never stronger than when people have had a taste of a 10x hotel. The interactions they have with other guests and staff are richer and more fulfilling than any other interactions available to them in their daily lives. The property, the location, and the facilities are more conducive

to health and well-being than anything available to them back home.

The healthy, natural, and entirely predictable response of at least fifty percent of guests is: I don't want to go home. How can I make this a more permanent part of my life?

This is where residencies come in — and it is something that beautiful, rural, low-cost land development makes genuinely possible.

The Economics of Shared Infrastructure

Before exploring the design of residencies, it is worth pausing on the opportunity that a well-developed property with extensive facilities already presents. The cost of a plunge pool, a sauna, a natural hot spring, a swimming lake, restaurants, and gardens are fixed costs. Many traditional hotels have a peak and a low season, meaning that facilities sit quiet and underutilized for as much as seventy percent of the year.

Residencies change this entirely. When people live on or adjacent to the property, those facilities are in constant, loving use. The fixed costs are shared across a larger community, which makes it possible to offer facilities of a

quality that would be economically difficult to justify for guests alone.

The Synergy Between Guests and Residents

People are the central feature of any 10x experience. The chance to find a place you love, and to have high-quality interactions with people who share your values and interests, is a significant part of what makes a 10x lifestyle compelling.

Residencies create a profound synergy. For residents, the steady flow of guests brings diversity, new perspectives, and the pleasure of meeting interesting people from around the world. For guests, residents offer something rarer: the chance to speak with people who have chosen this life, who know the property intimately, and who can speak honestly about what it means to live here rather than simply visit. If a guest forms a genuine friendship with a resident, every future visit to the hotel becomes a homecoming.

There is also a practical dimension. Residents who have completed host training become a natural pool from which team members can be drawn — people who already understand the culture, love the property, and are, in many cases, happy to contribute their time and skills. Residents

might also generate income for themselves by growing fresh organic vegetables for the hotel kitchen, offering laundry services, creating crafts and art, or providing custom catering — all of which enriches the hotel's offering without adding to its payroll.

Designing the Residency

The architecture of the residences should echo and strengthen the hotel's design language. If concrete domes are used as guest villas, the residences should carry similar finishing, so that residents experience the same quality they enjoyed as guests, and so that the contractors and construction team are already accustomed to the forms. Five distinct modules or patterns can be offered — from a single-room writer's retreat to a two-bedroom family dome — allowing prospective residents to choose the configuration that suits their life.

To ensure cultural fit, a resident might first be offered the option to rent a property for up to a year before being given the option to purchase. Given that the entire focus of the community is on a 10x experience, it is essential that every resident is genuinely excited to be present — not

merely a property owner, but a participant in the life of the place.

Two styles of residency can be made available. The first is a condominium model, in which the hotel builds and maintains the residences, and people purchase or lease them for a defined period with full access to hotel facilities. The second is a more independent model, in which an adjoining piece of land is purchased by the resident, who builds their own home and buys a pass to use hotel facilities. Both models serve different temperaments and financial situations, and both contribute to the community.

A Community Within the World

The model is simple: continually iterate and perfect the 10x experience within the hotel, and then support others in bringing many aspects of that experience into their ongoing lives.

A community of up to one hundred local residents keeps things intimate, warm, and interesting. At this scale, everyone knows everyone. New faces are welcomed rather than lost in a crowd. And for the residents themselves, the combination of natural beauty, meaningful community, excellent facilities, and a cost of living that would be

impossible to replicate in any major city makes it one of the best places on earth to live. The hotel gave them a taste of a dream lifestyle. Committing to residency allows them to embrace it and sustainably live it.

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Chapter Eleven

10X Architecture

Most hotel architecture is designed to impress on arrival and forgotten by morning. The 10x approach asks a different question: what is the highest-value structure that can be built at the lowest cost, maintained with the least effort, and lived in with the most pleasure? The answers, it turns out, point clearly in one direction.

The Criteria for Superior Construction:

Cost, ease, and speed of construction. One of the most direct ways to increase value per dollar is to lower the

cost of building while maintaining the same quality of experience.

Mold resistance. Water damage, leaking into carpets and wood, and various forms of toxic mold are major health risks. A building that eliminates the possibility of mold, dry rot, and wood decay is superior to one that does not.

Fire resistance. A construction method that can withstand an exterior garden or forest fire and contain an interior fire is vastly superior to a structure that cannot.

Soundproofing. The less sound travels between a building and the outside world, or between one room and another, the greater the privacy and the greater the quality of attention within the space. Complete sound isolation between rooms is extraordinarily valuable — and allows for long, luxurious sleep.

Resistance to falling objects. In forest environments, falling trees and large branches are a real risk. A structure that can protect its occupants when a tree or large branch falls onto it — without harming people or requiring major repairs — is superior.

Visual beauty and respect for views. Any building that is visually beautiful and does not obscure natural views by being overly large or tall is superior to an ugly building or one that blocks the landscape around it.

Fostering human engagement. Architecture that regularly brings people together for social interaction is superior to architecture that isolates them.

Accessibility. Any space that is fully accessible by a wheelchair user, an elderly person with a walker, and by infants and young children is superior to one that is not.

Independent utilities. Any building or compound that generates its own electricity, water, and internet access is superior to one that relies entirely on outside infrastructure.

Participation and engagement. Whenever people have the opportunity to participate in the construction of their own home or community, the result is increased pride, increased self-confidence, and increased commitment to the success of the project and the community it creates.

The Pattern That Emerges:

With these criteria in mind, a clear pattern emerges: small, independent, soundproof, and private sleeping areas,

clustered around central cooking, laundry, and community facilities.

By eliminating personal kitchens, personal movie rooms, personal living rooms, and individual laundry facilities, each resident is able to avoid substantial waste, save a considerable amount of money, and is drawn naturally into engagement with others — in the course of bathing, using the sauna, cooking, eating, doing laundry, watching films, and more. The money saved by removing these duplicated private facilities can instead be used to create truly extraordinary shared spaces that everyone enjoys, and that actually get used.

The Dome:

The sphere is one of the most beautiful shapes in existence, and for good reason. It is the single strongest and most structurally efficient shape there is, distributing load evenly and requiring the thinnest possible membrane to hold its form. There is also something deeply human about being inside a sphere — it recalls, in some quiet way, both the earth and the womb from which we came. There are a few rooms in which it is nicer to sleep.

A dome is the most practical realization of this idea: a circular space with a domed roof. For sleeping areas, it provides a wonderful surface to look up at — an opportunity for art, texture, and beauty overhead. It also happens to be one of the lowest-cost and easiest construction techniques available.

Depending on the environment, a dome can be built as a single one-to-two-inch thick ferrocement and steel structure — created by experts or enthusiastic amateurs, since the techniques are easy to learn and apply. Alternatively, it can be built as a two-layer system with an insulating foam core that increases both soundproofing and thermal insulation. A concrete and steel structure of this nature is earthquake-proof, fireproof, hurricane-proof, waterproof, and mildew-proof — and easy to maintain over a hundred-year period.

Double or triple-paned vinyl windows further enhance soundproofing and insulation, and are immune to rot. Doors can be ornate wood, painted steel, or vinyl, according to individual preference.

The Community Building:

By clustering individual domes in groups of five to ten around a central community building, the community building itself can be rectangular and roofed with solar panels. The roof provides shade, water protection, and wind protection over the community space, which consists of a large common room, kitchen, tool area, laundry room, and extensive spa facilities.

A More Efficient Solar Roof:

Rather than mounting solar panels on top of standard roofing, four-by-eight-foot solar panels can be laid directly on a steeply pitched roof with a one-inch gap between them, sealed with a silicone-type adhesive. This eliminates the need for conventional roofing beneath, simplifies access to the electrical wiring, and reduces cost. A bamboo weave, preserved and fixed to the underside of the structure, can conceal the panels for a natural aesthetic — or, for a more industrial look, the semi-translucent panels can be left exposed, allowing filtered natural light and shade beneath.

Ferrocement Construction:

Ferrocement is a strong, durable material reinforced with steel mesh, steel zip ties, rebar, and occasionally other

structural steel elements. The technique is simple enough to be learned and applied by almost anyone with a single day of instruction.

First, a steel frame is constructed from rebar, galvanized pipe, and angle iron in whatever shape is desired. Second, steel mesh is zip-tied onto this frame as the adhesion surface for the ferrocement, which is applied in layers. Finally, the exterior is sealed with waterproof paint or concrete sealer, which can be clear or in any color. The interior can be left as natural concrete — with or without a dye — or plastered and painted. Depending on the intention, it can be perfectly symmetrical or pleasingly rustic, with the natural charm that comes from volunteers or enthusiastic amateurs doing the work.

The ability to bend rebar and four-by-eight-foot sheets of wire mesh into any form is what makes this such a remarkable building material. Being single-storey, it carries very little structural load. And being a dome, the stronger the wind blows, the more the roof is pressed toward the ground — rather than lifted from it.

How Ferrocement Domes Score on Key Metrics:

The following scores reflect the performance of ferrocement domes across every metric that matters in construction. To the author's knowledge, no other building type scores as highly across this range simultaneously. Scores are on a scale of 1 to 10.

Criteria	Score / 10
Fire proof	10
Mold & mildew resistant	10
Sound-proof	9
Impact resistant (falling trees)	10
Earthquake proof	10
Heating and cooling efficiency	10
Durability (lifespan)	10
Cost to build	10
Building speed	10
Ecological design	8
Volunteer buildable	10
Quiet construction	10
Shape flexibility	10
Supply chain simplicity	10
Exterior beauty	10
Interior beauty	10
Does not block views	10
Cost to maintain	10
Off-grid suitability	10
Suitable for slopes and Hobbit Homes	10
Total (out of 200)	**197**

** Ferrocement domes, similar to those featured on the book cover, are ideal for larger, rural areas of less expensive land. They are not suitable for expensive city plots, where multi-story construction better utilizes the space.*

A ferrocement dome is currently the most highly rated design for individual and couple sleeping areas, creating a building module for clusters of individuals around rich common areas which draw people together in a shared community. By deleting 60–90% of the individual facilities in a typical Western home, it does something profound. When each individual does not have their own garage, car, tool-set, game room, media room, dining room, kitchen, laundry, and bathing areas, it creates 10x more utilization of these features in common areas. While common in hotels, this is a huge transformation when it comes to residences, and provides a large amount of money available to make some of the most extraordinary common areas on earth.

Tiny Homes, Domes and Walkable Compounds:

As I write this chapter, I am watching a typical compound being developed next door. In step one, several acres of land are being systematically flattened, as most of the aesthetic and ecological value of the natural forest is destroyed. As a landscape architect, I know it would cost at

least a million dollars to restore the vegetation and old-growth plantings — and even then, there is no transportation mechanism to replace the older trees. This is being done so that an interesting and diverse hilly slope can be completely flattened before a soulless subdivision is installed. Next will come the installation of a gym so people can get exercise artificially. Lost are the hilly views, nooks, boulders, trees, and interesting trails.

This is the true beauty of small, custom-sized domes, which can be dug into hills as Hobbit Homes, have living roofs when desired, and can be placed easily on many slopes. This not only has the substantial benefit of saving money clearing land, saving money landscaping land, and providing more natural beauty per dollar of development, but it also allows one to buy parcels of land for less that have more beauty, because most developers pay more for flat land. The resident receives maximum value. The Earth receives minimal harm. The developer saves money by buying and developing the land.

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Chapter Twelve

Some Thoughts on Funding

Anything that is truly 10x is going to be different. And anything that is ten times better and different will often struggle to get funding. One need only look at the fact that Airbnb was turned down by every investor it initially approached, or that The Lord of the Rings was published by Rayner Unwin with the note "this is a worthy project which we know will lose money" — to understand that investors do not understand people well enough to know what they hunger for.

This chapter looks at several ways to work around that.

The good news is that even though banks and investors do not understand people well enough to know what they hunger for, your friends and ordinary human beings can understand why living in a 10x environment is an extraordinary opportunity — and they can sign up. Prospective residents can also commit early and receive discounts in exchange for their support during the initial infrastructure phase.

Land: The Lease Option:

If you follow the pattern of acquiring a rural, low-cost piece of beautiful, pristine land rather than a prized piece of city real estate, you may easily find yourself the only person bidding on the property. In that context, a lease option becomes a powerful tool.

A lease option works like this: you go to the landowner and say, you haven't sold this land in five years, and you may not sell it in the next five either. But if you make it available to me for a five-year period, I will give you a certain amount of money now and the balance within five years. Given that genuinely beautiful fifty-acre properties exist in various parts of the world for a few hundred thousand dollars, and given that a large percentage of

people around the world would pay hundreds of thousands of dollars to live in a 10x environment, this is a solid foundation from which to begin. It takes much of the cost of the land off the table before revenues from sales even arrive.

Funding Through Residencies:

Having secured the land, you can begin developing it through residency sales. Using a ferrocement dome compound as the first module, you might sell ten residences at $150,000 each — generating $1,500,000. The residencies and their infrastructure might cost $750,000, leaving $750,000 to begin constructing the hotel and its facilities. A second round of residency sales can follow, funding the next module.

In parallel, you can begin building the hotel itself in stages. Build the first five domes and begin hosting guests in intimate, niche ways — creating genuine 10x experiences for five people at a time. Given how many people around the world are drawn to workshops on natural and alternative building, you could host a ferrocement dome-building workshop: participants learn the art of building tiny home domes in exchange for room and board and a

modest deposit, generating both publicity and skilled volunteer labor for the build.

Growing Organically:

Going slowly and expanding in modules — systematically growing the community and its infrastructure using profits and residency sales — is another path entirely, and often a more organic and enjoyable one. If you have never managed a large project before and you have five years before a balloon payment on the land comes due, there is real value in taking your time.

Find good people. Build a few domes. Find and train excellent hosts, or act as one yourself. Let guests arrive, have extraordinary experiences, and begin asking whether they can become residents. As long as a healthy profit margin is built into each residency, every new resident becomes both an ally and a source of capital to keep developing the community facilities, which in turn benefits residents and guests alike, generating even more interest in joining. It creates a wonderful sense of positive momentum without anyone feeling overwhelmed.

A clear vision and strategy for the whole property can be laid out from the beginning. Budgets can be set for each infrastructure element. Cash flow from residency sales and a small number of guests can be carefully allocated, with a portion of every sale directed toward paying off the land.

Once you no longer need the money and have a complete proof of concept, banks become far more willing to lend. If you complete the first module profitably and can show working financials, you can approach a bank to fund the second module more quickly. But the truth is, it is often easier — and more satisfying — to leave banks out of the picture altogether.

The world is full of people desperate for 10x experiences — and most of them have never been offered one. The funding will follow the vision. The most important thing of all is assembling a competent team that can deliver on every promise made.

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Chapter Thirteen

The Joy of Animals

There is a moment that every guest experiences, though few can name it precisely. It happens when a dog wanders over and rests its head in their lap, or when a rabbit settles into stillness beside them on the grass, or when a bird lands unexpectedly nearby and simply stays. Something shifts. The breath slows. The shoulders drop. The internal monologue quiets.

This is not sentimentality. It is neuroscience.

Consider where most guests are arriving from. Staying up at all hours, exposed to synthetic lights and synthetic

sounds, stimulated by chemicals and screens, and above all by their phones, in ways that 99.9% of our ancestors never experienced. We have never been more separated from our bodies and our own nervous systems than we are right now.

When we interact with an animal, we are interacting with a part of ourselves and our own biological history that has not been touched by modernity. We are invited to attune to a quiet, peaceful way of being — playful, vital, present. Animals give us an experience that no person suffering from the same anxiety, isolation, and disconnection can provide. They don't judge. They are extraordinarily forgiving. As human touch becomes both more politicized and more rare in modern life, animals offer something irreplaceable: a warm, safe, and regulating presence.

The Science of Nervous System Regulation:

The human nervous system is exquisitely sensitive to signals of safety. When those signals are present — warmth, softness, slow movement, non-threatening presence — the parasympathetic nervous system activates, cortisol drops, and the body begins to repair itself. Animals provide these signals effortlessly and constantly.

A study in BMC Psychiatry found that patients who spent eight weeks with a bird showed significant improvements in happiness and quality of life across four measured domains — psychological well-being, social relationships, environment, and autonomy. Research from UCLA Health confirmed that just fifteen minutes with a therapy animal can lower blood pressure, reduce heart rate, and measurably decrease anxiety. A 2024 systematic review examining sixteen studies across populations with depression, anxiety, PTSD, and schizophrenia concluded that animal-assisted therapy showed consistent promise as an effective intervention for well-being across diverse groups.

The mechanism is well understood. Physical interaction with animals triggers the release of oxytocin — the bonding hormone — within as little as three minutes. Oxytocin, in turn, suppresses cortisol. Simultaneously, endorphins, dopamine, serotonin, and phenylethylamine are released, creating a neurochemical environment associated with calm, pleasure, and connection. The effect is not subtle. It is one of the most cost-effective and immediate interventions for nervous system dysregulation available to any hospitality property.

During a period of my own life when anxiety and isolation were at their worst, my dog was the only reliably safe and secure relationship I had. I noticed that less than an hour a day with him increased the quality of my well-being by as much as thirty percent, while costing approximately a dollar a day to sustain. When I ran the numbers against a ten-thousand-dollar-a-month lifestyle, the thirty dollars a month I spent on my dog — for a thirty percent sustainable improvement in well-being — made it the single most intelligent investment in my life.

Animals are also good for our longevity. Studies consistently show that animal companionship lifts depression, which remains one of the most common and costly human diseases. And beyond all the science: they are simply fun. A dog with its tongue out, trotting without a care, can remind us that we do not have to be perfect in order to be lovable. That alone is worth a great deal of therapy.

Community Dogs:

Dogs are the most studied and consistently effective therapy animals in existence. Their capacity to read human emotional states — developed over fifteen thousand years

of co-evolution with humans — makes them uniquely suited to a hospitality environment. A community dog is not a pet belonging to any one person but a well-trained, well-loved member of the community who circulates among guests and residents freely.

Travelling extensively, I noticed how few hotels were dog-friendly, and how much the immigration hassle and expense of bringing a dog from one country to another meant that guests arrived already missing animal contact. I found myself happily playing with strangers' dogs whenever I encountered them. The community dog model solves this entirely — the dog is already there, already at home, already delighted to meet whoever arrives.

The dogs are expertly trained, regularly handled by staff, and given clear areas of rest and retreat.

Rabbits:

Rabbits are among the most underrated animals in a therapeutic context. Their calm, soft presence, the way they settle into stillness beside a person, and their gentle responsiveness make them ideal for guests of all ages. A rabbit in one's lap is one of the simplest and most effective nervous system regulators available — the softness, the

warmth, the slow breathing of the animal all communicate safety directly to the body.

In a rural property, rabbits live in a semi-wild enclosure that guests can enter — a space of quiet, soft movement and grass, entirely unlike anything available in an urban environment. They are also wonderful with children, teaching young guests how to be gentle, attentive, and present with another living creature.

Goats:

Goats are curious, playful, and entirely without pretension. They approach humans with an almost comic confidence, investigate everything within reach, and create instant delight in adults and children alike. Research on farm animal-assisted therapy shows benefits to coping skills, self-efficacy, and emotional grounding through the structured tasks of feeding and gentle handling.

On a rural property, a small herd of goats also serves a practical function — grazing, maintaining vegetation, and generating the background sounds and movement of a working farm that guests find deeply settling.

Birds:

Birds occupy a unique sensory register. Their song regulates the human nervous system in ways that few other stimuli can match — birdsong has been shown to reduce stress and improve mood in natural environments, and is one of the primary reasons guests describe nature settings as restorative. On a 10x property, a varied bird population — both wild and semi-domestic — creates a soundscape that begins working on guests the moment they arrive.

Beyond wild birds, keeping domesticated birds — doves, quail, or heritage breeds — adds visual beauty and gentle sound to common areas. The BMC Psychiatry study used a single bird as its only therapeutic intervention and still produced significant improvements across all four quality-of-life domains in its participant group.

Chickens:

Even chickens are calming, fun, and genuinely beautiful companions. Bantam hens and heritage breed chickens move through gardens with an unhurried authority. Their sounds are deeply associated with peaceful rural life, and collecting eggs is one of those simple, grounding experiences that guests remember long after checkout. From a practical standpoint, chickens contribute to the

kitchen — fresh eggs from birds the guest has watched that morning, connecting the meal to the land in a way no supply chain ever could.

Ponies:

Equine-assisted therapy is one of the most well-documented forms of animal-assisted intervention. Horses and ponies have shown consistent benefits for emotional regulation, confidence, and self-esteem — particularly for guests dealing with anxiety, trauma, or disconnection from their own bodies. Horses mirror human emotional states, responding visibly to tension and relaxing visibly when it resolves, making the regulation process tangible and immediate.

On a rural property, ponies rather than full-sized horses are often more practical — easier to house, gentler with guests who have no riding experience, and entirely capable of providing the same relational and therapeutic benefits. A morning walk with a pony through the property is a first-time memory that no urban hotel can offer.

The Animal Space:

A dedicated room or special garden area for being with animals becomes one of the most popular spaces in any hotel that features them. Animals offer something rarer than novelty: a reason to return. What better reason to come back to a 10x hotel than the memory of a particular animal — a dog that chose you, a pony that followed you down a trail, a rabbit that fell asleep in your lap — and the simple pleasure of looking forward to spending time with them again.

All animals are an option — in a safe and well-tended space that people ready to enjoy the love of animals can visit. They are, for many guests, the most memorable part of the stay — and the most quietly powerful contribution to the nervous system regulation, joy, and sense of aliveness that the 10x experience is designed to create.

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Chapter Fourteen

The Experience Menu

Imagine you have just checked in — or you are waiting to check in — and a member of the team hands you a tablet. On it is a beautifully designed menu. Not a food menu. An experience menu.

Each item has a title, a short description, and two buttons: Curious and Excited. You tap through slowly, reading each one. By the time you reach your room, you already know what tomorrow morning looks like.

Menu of Solitude

- **The Silence Room.** A dedicated room where no speaking takes place. Guests enter, sit, and remain for as long as they like. No guided meditation, no music. Just the experience of being with other people in complete silence — rarer than most guests expect, and more valuable than almost anything else on the menu.
- **The Dark Room.** A specially designed room with no light and no sound. Meals are passed silently through a small hatch on a pre-arranged menu. Time slows down. The mind, deprived of its usual inputs, turns inward in ways that are difficult to describe and easy to remember. Available for a set number of hours or days.
- **A Letter to Your Future Self.** Write to yourself as you are right now — what you felt, what you noticed, what you want to remember. The hotel mails it to you twelve months later. You open it alone, at home, in your ordinary life, and meet the person you were here.

Menu for Partners

- **Eye Gazing.** Sit opposite a willing partner and maintain eye contact for two minutes without speaking. Drawn from contemplative traditions and

validated by social neuroscience, this experience creates a level of human connection that most people have not experienced since childhood.

- **Blindfolded Sunrise Meditation.** You and a partner sit together at the water's edge at dawn, both blindfolded. A guide leads a twenty-minute practice. Without sight, sound becomes extraordinary — the water, the birds, the breathing of the person beside you.
- **Private Chef's Table.** Dinner is prepared and served for two at a table set beside the river or under the trees by a chef who talks through every dish. The food is from the property. The experience is unlike any restaurant.

Menu with Animals

- **Bird Petting.** Enter the aviary and let the birds come to you. A dove lands on your shoulder. A quail investigates your shoe. There is nothing to do but be still and let it happen.
- **Rabbit Sitting.** A rabbit is placed in your lap. That is the entire experience. It settles. Its breathing slows. So does yours.

- **Horse Therapy Session.** A one-on-one session with a trained equine facilitator and one of the property's ponies. Not riding — being. The pony responds to your emotional state in real time, and what it shows you about yourself is often more illuminating than a year of conventional therapy.

Menu of Rituals

- **Tell Your Burdens to the Fire.** Each guest speaks one weight aloud to the fire and releases it in turn. A circular bonfire, a facilitated ritual, and the particular courage it takes to say something true out loud in front of strangers.
- **The Big Book of Gratitude.** A large, beautifully bound book sits open in the common room. Write whatever you want. Read what others wrote before you. The cumulative effect of hundreds of entries — from guests spanning many countries and many years — is unexpectedly moving.
- **The Blessing Meal.** Certain dinners begin with a moment of communal gratitude — each guest invited to offer one word of thanks before eating. Simple, non-religious, and quietly transformative for guests

who have never experienced a meal that began with stillness.

- **The Wishing Ceremony.** At dusk, each guest writes a wish on a small piece of paper, folds it, and places it in a lantern. The lanterns are released together over the water. The ritual is ancient. The effect is immediate.
- **Anonymous Notes of Kindness.** Write something true and generous — an observation, a word of encouragement — and leave it anonymously for another guest or a team member. Receive one in return. The effect on both writer and recipient is reliably disproportionate to the effort involved.
- **The Meal Blessing.** Before every meal, a guest who has signed up in advance offers a blessing to the group — one sentence, in any tradition or none. Over the course of a stay, guests hear blessings from a dozen different cultures, languages, and hearts. Those who have never spoken one discover they have one waiting.
- **The Gratitude Circle.** Guests sit in a circle at the end of their final evening. Each person offers one genuine appreciation — for the property, a team member, another guest, or something they noticed in

themselves. No speeches. Just one true thing, said aloud.

- **The Departure Blessing.** When a guest is ready to leave, a team member brings them a small crystal on a necklace and offers a blessing: "May you be blessed, safe, and well until your return to our hotel. Thank you for coming." They then place the necklace around the guest's neck. It is a small gesture. It lands like something much larger.

Friendship Menu

- **The Great Conversation Table.** A round table is set each evening where guests who want to meet new people can sit. An open question is placed at the center — not an icebreaker, but a real question, the kind that reveals something. No one is obligated to attend. Everyone who does remembers it.

- **The Daily Connection Hour.** A facilitated hour each day is built around quizzes, games, and sharing circles. Prompts include: "If you really knew me, you would know…" and "One of my personal goals right now is…" Guests who arrive as strangers leave as people who know something real about each other.

- **The Cuddle Room.** After dinner, the cuddle room opens — a warm, softly lit space with cushions, blankets, and a trained facilitator. Platonic touch, offered and received freely, with clear and simple agreements in place. For many guests, it is the first time in years they have been held without an agenda. The nervous system knows the difference.

Games Menu

- **The Property Treasure Hunt.** A map, a series of clues, and a puzzle that can only be solved by exploring every corner of the property. Guests work alone or in pairs. The clues are witty, the locations are beautiful, and the solution requires genuine thought. Whoever solves it receives their prize at dinner that evening — announced to the room. Children and adults compete on equal terms.

Skills Menu

- **Dome-Building Workshop.** Spend a half-day learning the art of ferrocement construction alongside the property's team and other guests. You leave knowing how to build a structure that lasts a hundred

years. A genuinely rare skill, taught in a setting that makes it feel like play.

- **Acrylic Pouring Studio.** A dedicated painting room with all materials provided, a brief introductory class, and YouTube tutorials playing on screen from master teachers. Guests pour, tilt, and watch color bloom across the canvas in patterns that are never quite the same twice. The results are always surprising. Finished paintings can be left at the hotel — displayed in the common areas — or taken home.

- **The Content Studio.** A small, well-equipped media and AI room where guests learn to create beautiful social media content about their stay — short films, photo essays, reels, and stories — with guidance on tools, editing, and storytelling. Guests leave with skills they will use long after checkout. The hotel benefits from a steady stream of authentic, inspired content created by the people who love it most.

Health Menu

- **Cold Plunge and Heat Cycling.** Move between cold water immersion and heat — sauna, steam, or hot spring — in alternating cycles. An ancient practice now

validated by substantial research on inflammation, mood, and cardiovascular health. The effect on the body and mind by the final cycle is profound, and consistently described by guests as addictive in the best possible sense.

- **Breathwork Ceremony.** A facilitated two-hour session using specific breathing techniques to achieve altered states, emotional release, and a deep nervous system reset. No substances involved. A growing body of peer-reviewed research supports its efficacy for anxiety, trauma, and emotional processing. Consistently produces results that guests describe as among the most significant experiences of their adult lives.

- **Private Sound Bath.** A trained practitioner performs a private session using singing bowls, tuning forks, and breathwork. The nervous system response is measurable. The subjective experience is often described as the deepest rest guests have had in years.

- **The Digital Detox.** Your host takes your phone. And your laptop. And your tablet. You nominate two people whose urgent messages will be monitored and

passed on if truly necessary. Everyone else can wait. What follows — often within hours — is a physical sensation of relief that most guests did not expect to feel so quickly or so strongly. Most guests don't ask for their devices back early.

- **The Ketogenic Reset.** A personal meal plan is designed for you — no sugar, no starch, for the duration of your stay. The kitchen designs dishes specifically to make the protocol genuinely pleasurable: rich, satisfying, beautifully presented food that happens to contain none of what depletes you. You learn to cook three of your favorite dishes from the program. You leave with the recipes, the knowledge, and — typically within three to five days — a clarity of mind that most guests have not experienced in years.
- **Blue Zone Longevity Day.** A full day designed around the habits of the world's longest-lived communities — specific foods, movement patterns, social rituals, and purpose practices. Costa Rica's Nicoya Peninsula is itself one of the world's five Blue Zones, making this not an import but a local inheritance. Guests leave with a practical

understanding of what centenarians actually do, and why it is far more accessible than most people assume.

Self Discovery Menu

- **Floatation Therapy.** You float in a dark, body-temperature tank of dense saline solution for sixty to ninety minutes. The water supports your body completely. The darkness is total. A Swedish research study found measurable reductions in stress, depression, and anxiety, with significant increases in optimism. What most guests report is simpler: the deepest rest they have had in years, arrived at without effort.
- **Darkness Dinner.** Dinner served in complete darkness. Your other senses wake up immediately. The food tastes different. The conversation goes somewhere it would not have gone in the light.
- **Psychedelic-Assisted Therapy.** Where legal, facilitated sessions using psilocybin or other plant medicines are offered in a carefully prepared setting with trained guides. The growing body of clinical research — including landmark studies from Johns Hopkins and Imperial College London — documents

extraordinary results for depression, anxiety, PTSD, and end-of-life distress. This is not recreational. It is one of the most significant therapeutic frontiers of our time, available here in the safest possible container.

- **The Clothing-Optional Spa.** The sauna, hot springs, and spa area include a clothing-optional section — a natural, unhurried space where the body is simply a body. For those who choose it, the experience of being at ease in one's own skin, without performance or judgment, is one of the quietest and most lasting forms of self-acceptance available.

This is a very small window into many things that I would not only love to experience as a hotel guest, but have never been invited to experience at any five star hotel I have stayed at. What are three things you would like to experience on this list, and at least one thing you would like to experience that is not on this list?

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Chapter Fifteen

The 10X Hotel App

The 10x hotel app is among the most powerful tools available to a modern hotel — and it is getting cheaper to build by the day. It is not a booking system. It is not a payment terminal. It is the invisible backbone of the entire 10x experience — the mechanism by which every guest is known, every team member is supported, and every owner is informed. One app. Used across all 10x hotels worldwide.

It is your second morning. You slept well. You open the app and see that Maria, your host, has left a note: "You mentioned yesterday that you were hoping to feel more

rested by the end of the week. I noticed you booked the breathwork session for Thursday — I moved you to the smaller group on Wednesday instead, which I think you will prefer. Your avocado toast is already in the kitchen. The rabbits are out in the garden if you feel like starting slowly." You have not asked for any of this. The hotel simply noticed.

That is what the app is for. Everything below is how it makes that possible.

The Guest Experience:

Everything the guest touches begins here. Before they arrive. During their stay. Long after they leave.

Profile and preferences. The guest's profile holds their allergies, dietary preferences, favorite dishes, favorite room, emergency contact, passport details, and personal interests. It remembers the highlights of every previous stay. It knows their birthday. When they arrive at a new 10x hotel anywhere in the world, they are already known.

Pre-arrival. Guests browse the experience menu, select what interests them, log standing food orders, and note anything the team should know before they arrive. The

hotel reads all of this before the guest sets foot on the property. The room is ready. The kitchen knows. The host has been briefed.

Arrival. GPS location tells the hotel when the guest is minutes away. A team member is at the entrance to greet them by name and take them directly to their room. There is no desk. There is no queue. There is no process — only arrival.

Ordering food. Guests order through the app. The kitchen receives it. When the dish is ready, the guest is notified to collect or have it delivered. Anything out of stock is marked instantly. No guest ever selects something only to be told it is unavailable.

Standing orders. A guest who wants the same breakfast every morning enters it once. It happens every day without prompting.

Booking experiences. Every ritual, class, session, workshop, and animal visit lives in the app. Guests self-book. The moment they confirm, that slot is closed for everyone else. Concierge as a function disappears.

Room access and payment. The app opens the room. All billing is automatic — no card machines, no printed invoices, no signatures. A waterproof watch version is available, so guests never need their phone at the pool or sauna. Guests can pre-load a balance and receive a two to three percent discount in place of credit card fees.

Social visibility. Guests set their own preference — visible or invisible. Visible means a simple profile showing interests and what they are open to. Guests can post impromptu invitations to the hotel calendar. Connections made during a stay continue through the app afterwards. When a friend in a guest's network books a return visit, an optional alert lets others know.

Daily well-being log. Guests are invited — never required — to note a daily high and low. The hotel tracks overall guest well-being in real time and responds when something shifts.

Photos, gratitude notes, and checkout. Staff photos from group activities appear in the app. Gratitude notes can be sent to any team member or guest with a single tap. Checkout takes ninety seconds, with an optional photo of the room to confirm everything is in order.

Guest goals. Each guest can share one or more goals for their stay — to rest, to connect, to learn something, to let go of something. These are visible to the team and, if the guest chooses, to other guests. At the end of the stay, the guest reflects on whether they were met. There is something quietly powerful about a hotel that asks what you came for and then tries to help you get it. Most guests have never been asked.

Referrals and return visits. The app tracks how many guests a person has referred to the hotel, how many times they have returned, and what brings them back. Vacancies and special availability are communicated directly to the guest network.

The Team Experience:

Scheduling. Team members manage their own availability, shift swaps, and time-off requests through the app. The roster is always current and visible to everyone.

Guest briefings. Before each shift, team members see who is arriving, who is staying, what their preferences are, what experiences they have booked, and any notes from previous interactions. A team member who has never met a guest can greet them as if they have.

Inventory and restocking. Based on guest standing orders, bookings, and consumption patterns, the app generates restocking alerts automatically. When integrated with suppliers, it places orders directly. The kitchen never runs out of what guests have pre-ordered.

Guest feedback per team member. Every piece of guest feedback is attributed to the specific team member involved — courtesy, warmth, competence, and meaningful interaction, rated individually. These accumulate into a genuine professional record over time.

Praise and recognition. Guests and fellow team members can send appreciation notes to any team member through the app. These are visible to the whole team and to the owner. Good work is seen.

Skill-building modules. The app hosts a structured curriculum covering active listening, the art of conversation, conflict resolution, giving and receiving feedback, emotional attunement, hosting skills, cooking techniques from the property kitchen, breathwork fundamentals, and the science of well-being. Each module is broken into short daily practices. Progress is tracked. Completed modules appear in the team member's

professional profile — a credential in human-centred hospitality that travels with them wherever they work.

Team goals. Each team member sets and shares one or more professional goals — skills to develop, areas to grow, things to learn. These are visible to the owner and to fellow team members. Progress is acknowledged. For many team members, this is the first workplace that has ever asked where they want to go.

The Owner Experience:

Real-time performance dashboard. The owner sees — at any moment, from anywhere in the world — every team member's start and finish times, hours worked, guest feedback scores, tip income, skill module progress, and praise received. A dip in ratings triggers an automatic alert. A spike in satisfaction can be traced to a specific person or experience and replicated immediately.

Trend analysis. Every metric has a trend line — guest satisfaction, team satisfaction, revenue, tip income, skill-building progress, referrals, inventory costs, and occupancy. The owner sees what is improving, what needs attention, and where to focus next.

Hotel goals. The owner sets goals for the hotel — financial targets, guest satisfaction benchmarks, team development milestones, and ecological commitments — and publishes them within the app. The whole team sees them. Progress is tracked together.

The owner network. A private forum within the app connects 10x hotel owners worldwide. Which experiences are driving the most tips? Which training modules are producing the biggest uplift in satisfaction? Which suppliers are delivering the best quality? This knowledge circulates freely. The goal is to raise the standard everywhere.

The Financial Case:

On a modest 30-room property at $150 per night and 70% occupancy, the conservative annual savings look like this:

Booking platform commissions eliminated. Guests book direct through the app rather than through Agoda, Expedia, or similar platforms. At 10% commission on $1,576,500 annual revenue, that is $157,650 returned to the hotel every year.

Four logistics roles redirected. Check-in staff, concierge, invoice handlers, and card machine operators are replaced by the app at an average saving of $1,500 per month each, $72,000 per year.

Additional savings. Food waste is reduced by automatic restocking based on actual consumption. Dynamic pricing based on real occupancy trends fills rooms that would otherwise sit empty. Marketing budget reduced or eliminated as the referral system fills rooms directly.

Total conservative annual saving: $229,650. App development and maintenance run approximately $30,000 per year — starting small and building over time. Net annual gain on a 30-room property: $199,650. Owners with larger operations or higher room rates can scale the math accordingly.

The Database:

Behind every interaction is a living database that grows richer with every stay.

For guests: name, birthday, passport, emergency contacts, allergies, dietary preferences, favorite room,

favorite dishes, experiences they have loved, highlights of previous stays, goals set and met, number of referrals made, and number of return visits.

For team members: skills completed, feedback received, goals set and progress made, hours worked, tip income over time, and modules in progress.

For the hotel: occupancy trends, revenue trends, satisfaction trends, inventory consumption patterns, referral sources, most and least popular experiences, and ecological metrics were tracked.

This database is the memory of the hotel. It is what makes every guest feel known, every team member feel seen, and every owner feel informed. It is what turns a single stay into a relationship.

What the App Replaces:

The marketing department. The front desk. The concierge. The paper roster. The card machine. The printed invoice. The verbal briefing. The guesswork.

What remains is the thing the hotel was always supposed to be: a place where people are genuinely cared for.

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Chapter Sixteen

Love as a 10X Paradigm

The word sounds soft. It is not. Every great human achievement — every enduring institution, every business that outlasted its founder, every community that held together through difficulty — was built by people who cared more about what they were making than what they were making from it.

Love, applied as an organizing principle for a business, is the most demanding standard available. It requires more thought, more consistency, and more courage than the pursuit of profit — because profit asks only one question, and love asks one for every person in the room.

Capitalism asks a simple question: how do we extract the most value for the least cost? From workers, from guests, from the land, from time itself. The name makes the priority clear. It is capital — placed above all other stakeholders, driving every decision in a predictable direction. Cheaper ingredients when a supplier offers them — and if those ingredients are less healthy, that is someone else's problem. Cheaper labor when it can be found — and if good people lose their jobs, that is the market working as intended. Cheaper materials when the ecological cost lands on someone else's children — and by then, nobody remembers who made the decision. And the person most betrayed by this system is usually the one running it — sacrificing their health, their time, and their presence with the people they love in pursuit of a number that was never going to deliver what they actually wanted.

The system has a track record. Ninety percent of businesses built on this model fail within ten years. The ones who succeed financially face a different question: did they enjoy it? Billionaires, as the research consistently shows, are no happier than the average person. The money arrived. The satisfaction did not follow.

The alternative organizing question is this: how can we give more — to ourselves, to our families, to our team, to our guests, to the land we are building on? This is what 10x Living — the nonprofit I founded — exists to explore. Its premise is that love, properly understood and properly practiced, is the condition for genuine financial sustainability. And it is more demanding, more rigorous, and more rewarding than anything the pursuit of profit alone has ever produced.

What does love look like in practice? It begins with the unwillingness to expediently betray a stakeholder. The guest is told about the construction next door before they book. The team member who is struggling is supported rather than replaced. The toxic product is not used regardless of the savings. Truth, in a love-based model, is the mechanism by which people make decisions that are genuinely good for them — and a hotel that operates this way earns a quality of trust that no marketing budget can manufacture.

What does love look like for an owner? It begins with designing a life that is actually worth living. Living at or near the hotel in an environment more beautiful than anywhere else they could afford. Spending real time with their family

in a place already rich with animals, art, conversation, and human warmth. The average commuter spends eleven days a year in traffic. The average father spends less than ten minutes a day with his children. The 10x hotel owner, living and working on the property, gets both of those back. The greatest gift a 10x hotel gives its owner is life.

What does love look like for the team? It means paying people more than they could earn elsewhere, as a consequence of genuinely caring about their well-being. It means asking where they want to go professionally and building a path there. It means designing their working environment with the same care as the guest environment. A team member who lives inside the 10x culture every day delivers it to guests naturally and effortlessly.

What does love look like for the guest? Every decision about their experience is made by asking what would actually serve them. What would make their stay genuinely better? The hotel remembers who they are. It creates the conditions for rest, connection, and transformation rather than the performance of luxury.

What does love look like for the planet? It looks like a builder pausing in a hardware store and choosing the

material that costs slightly more and lasts thirty years longer. It looks like a kitchen that composts, a roof that generates power, a garden that feeds the dining room. It looks like a hotel that is quieter than the road outside it, because the vehicles on the property run on electricity, and the construction was done with methods that leave no scars. For $100 per person per year, it is possible to plant enough trees to make every guest's stay carbon negative. The 10x hotel does not offset its impact reluctantly. It reverses it — and invites every guest and team member to be part of that reversal.

A love-based hotel is a more profitable one. People who feel genuinely cared for return. They refer others, and a single referred guest costs the hotel nothing in commission and nothing in marketing. They tip generously. They stay longer. The average stay at a hotel with a strong loyalty culture is forty percent longer than at a comparable property without one. A team that is well-paid, well-treated, and growing professionally stays longer, serves better, and attracts other extraordinary people. A building built with quality materials costs less to maintain over twenty years than a cheap one costs in ten.

Love transcends money — and in transcending it, tends to produce more of it, more sustainably, for longer.

The 10x hotel is this paradigm in its most practical and most beautiful form. Every chapter of this book has described one dimension of what it looks like when a hotel is built around the question of how to genuinely serve the people inside it. The experience menu. The architecture. The animals. The app. The residencies. The team. All of it is love made concrete — made into policies, rituals, materials, relationships, and daily decisions.

The world does not need more hotels. It needs more places where people feel genuinely cared for — and more owners, builders, and hosts who have decided that creating such a place is what their working life is for.

This book is an invitation to be one of them.

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Chapter Seventeen

Getting Started

The enemy of the good is perfection. A 10x hotel is not built in a day, and waiting until everything is ready before taking the first step is the surest way to never begin. The ideas in this book are not a checklist to complete before opening. They are a direction to move in — and the movement itself, taken one step at a time, is what builds the culture. A leather-bound gratitude book placed in the common room this afternoon is worth more than a year of planning to place it perfectly.

Whether you are starting from scratch or improving an existing hotel, here are seven ways to begin today.

One. Hire for the mission. Advertise specifically for team members who are genuinely interested in creating a 10x experience for guests. You do not need to have the full program in place before you do this. Simply outlining the mission will begin attracting the kind of people who have been waiting for exactly this kind of invitation. Intelligent staff will understand immediately that a guest who has just had the best experience of their holiday tips differently than one who has had an ordinary one. The financial incentive and the human incentive point in exactly the same direction. In some cases you can bring new talent on as independent contractors, give them the mission, and let them work out the details with direct guest feedback.

Two. Start a YouTube channel. Document everything you are thinking about and doing to make your hotel better. Share the ideas, the experiments, the things that worked, and the things that did not. If a guest is browsing a hundred hotels and comes across one that is openly and ambitiously working to give them a ten times better experience, that is immediately more interesting than every other option on the list. The channel builds trust before the guest arrives and community long after they leave.

Three. Aim for one 10x hour per guest. You are not going to transform every moment of every stay immediately — and you do not need to. Reach out to each guest before they arrive and invite them to brainstorm with you. Tell them you want to create at least one genuinely extraordinary experience during their stay and ask what that might look like for them. Review the list together. Then look across your current guest list — someone who wants a particular experience may find that another guest has exactly the skill or interest to help create it. A retired chef. A meditation teacher on holiday. A photographer who would love a reason to shoot at dawn. Your guests are a resource you have not yet opened. Over a single week, capture what worked on video and share it. This is how the experience menu gets built — one guest at a time.

Four. Start with a dog. Find a friendly hotel dog and a team member who loves animals and is good with people. That is the entire program. The research on animal-assisted therapy is clear, the guest response is immediate, and the cost is negligible. It is also, for many guests, the first step toward something they did not know they were looking for.

Five. Introduce two rituals. One for arrival. One for departure. They do not need to be elaborate. A warm,

specific, personal greeting when a guest arrives — something that makes them feel seen rather than processed — and a genuine send-off when they leave. These two moments frame the entire stay and cost nothing except attention.

Six. Have your team read this book. It is the most efficient briefing available. Once they have read it, ask each team member for five ideas on how to make the hotel more 10x. The people closest to the guest experience will have ideas that no consultant or owner would think of. Ask for them. Write them down. Act on the best ones immediately. A team member who sees their idea implemented the following week becomes a different kind of employee — one who is invested in the outcome rather than just the shift.

Seven. Ask every guest what they think. Not in a form. In a conversation. Offer a small gift or a free fifteen-minute massage while you do it. Take notes. Then act on everything that costs less than a hundred dollars and meaningfully improves the experience. A large leather-bound gratitude book costs less than a hundred dollars and can be placed in the common room today. A welcome ritual costs nothing. The commitment to take action on what

guests tell you costs nothing either — and it changes everything.

The 10x hotel is not a destination. It is a practice. Every small step taken in the direction of genuinely caring for the people inside it moves the whole property closer to something rare and worth building.

Begin.

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A 10X Network

An Invitation

Networks are one of the most powerful ways to compound skill and leverage success. A network of individuals, teams, non-profits, and companies focused on 10x design and creating the best experiences on earth is a fun and powerful network to be a part of.

You are invited!

10XHotel.com

Everything you need to know about joining, contributing, and being part of what comes next.

Bonus Chapter

Hotel Highs and Lows

Let's start with the worst.

I arrived at my favorite hotel and met a fellow guest who had some symptoms of a cold. Two days later, I developed symptoms of COVID. I called the hotel concierge to ask if they could get me some vitamins and basic medicine. I could barely get out of bed, and they suggested that I get out of bed, go out, and hunt around at local pharmacies — infecting everyone along the way. I was sick. I didn't want to infect other people. And I was too tired to argue with them.

Then I emailed the hotel, listing the medicine I wanted, telling them I was sick and not to disturb me, that I would

contact them when I was awake. Five hours later, I had not gotten a reply. I emailed again, trying another email address, and was told to go to a pharmacy.

I got my virtual assistant involved, which prompted a flurry of emails back and forth. I went back to bed, exhausted, with a Do Not Disturb sign on my door. I was woken up by loud ringing, which I ignored. Then it started again. I picked up long enough to say don't disturb me. They said that medicine had arrived, but that I needed to come down to the lobby and pay cash for it. I said charge it to the room. They said they wouldn't do it. Come down with my passport. I said I don't have cash — I'm sick — charge it to the room. They said no. I said I was going to leave for a new hotel as soon as I got better. They said that was fine, but they were going to send the medicine back.

I let my virtual assistant know what was going on. And this was the darkest moment.

I understood that this was terrible for the hotel. That the hotel was, in fact, inviting me to go out and infect everyone with COVID, including their own staff. I understood that this was the absolute antithesis of

hospitality, which has the same root word as hospital — a place of healing and rest.

I also understood that this was the only time I actually needed the concierge. These people who would tirelessly hunt for a taxi I didn't really need. Who would arrange boats to see temples I didn't need to see? And the only time in ten years that I actually needed them — to help me out, to keep other people healthy, and to get healthy myself — they were stubborn, dogmatic, disrespectful, and profoundly damaging to every single party involved.

The medicine cost only a hundred dollars in local currency. And this was a five-star hotel where I had spent probably fifty thousand dollars over the years. They had served me hundred-dollar meals with a signature. And apparently, they could not trust me with a hundred-dollar bill for medicine that would protect my health and the health of their staff and other guests. Over a dogmatic policy.

I also noted that multiple departments and multiple people were aware that I was sick and needed medicine. And no one had asked a single question relating to health and safety.

The hotel maid showed up to clean the room, inviting themselves to become super-spreaders. The protocol, in effect, interrupts the healing sleep of a patient with COVID. Ask a COVID patient to go out into the world and infect as many people as possible. Send hotel staff without masks into rooms occupied by people with COVID. Deny medicine. Disrespect Do Not Disturb signs. Ignore health-related emails. Leave a top-tier long-term guest angry, helpless, and resentful. And dump all of this onto a sick person — while urgently prioritizing hamburger deliveries in the hotel restaurant, making absolutely sure that no guest interested in poisoning themselves was kept waiting.

It was the single most backward thing I had ever experienced in hospitality around the world. And here it was at my favorite hotel, with complete and utter dogmatic stubbornness to the protocol.

I felt so disgusted and enraged that I didn't even want to look at these people in the eye. And it was maddening to know what they were fighting for so stubbornly. It was a protocol that would see hotel staff getting COVID, going home and infecting their families, spreading throughout the country, and shutting down tourism.

Even more enraging was the realization that the hotel was remote. The interest of dozens of staff members who would kindly ask how my day was and tell me how nice it was to see me again — not one of them was there in the one time in ten years that I actually needed help from anyone. It was utterly lonely, bitter, miserable, and disgusting.

I wrote a long review, toning down my bitterness and disgust, hoping the staff might learn something. I don't know if they learned about what I thought was wrong. They were insisting on a protocol that made everyone sick, lost everyone money, created bad will, and was the antithesis of hospitality. Afterward, they certainly went out of their way to be gracious — smiling more, apologizing more.

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My next worst experience was at the same hotel, during a wave of intense emotional overwhelm. I was not ready to leave the hotel, go back to the United States, resume work, or do anything at all. I didn't know what to do or how to do it. I just knew I was physiologically and emotionally overwhelmed. Breathing was filling my lungs. I couldn't sleep well.

I found myself going into the shower, sitting on the floor, and letting the water run so my muscles felt less cold and less numb. For a time. Then hobbling back to bed and doing it over again an hour later, through the night.

What I wanted most of all was a sense of love and belonging. And I felt completely alone.

I get asked in my hotel often — maybe ten times a day — how are you? Is everything all right? Although it is lonely to break the facade, the illusion that people care enough to do something if everything is not all right, I find it even more lonely to lie. And so I answered: I felt absolutely miserable.

A horrifying answer for the anxious hotel staff.

Nevertheless, one of the senior team members asked me if there was anything he could do. And I said: yes, there is something you could do. I'm having a terrible time. We are surrounded by temples and monks. If you could ask any of the monks to come and sit with me for a bit, that would help enormously.

I was aware that monks do not charge. This would not cost the hotel any money. And of the three hundred

Buddhist hotel staff, some of them might have monks in the family.

But again, the same hotel that would scurry around the entire city looking for some obscure alcoholic beverage could not produce a monk. When I say could not, I don't mean that none of the three hundred staff could walk down the street and talk to a monk. They probably could, in much less time than it took them to fulfill many other requests, and they could do so for free. And it would have meant the world to me at a difficult moment.

What I mean is they could not understand how procuring a monk fit within their identity, or within the monk's identity, or within the hotel's identity. No doubt there were traditional protocols for engaging with monks, and they understood that asking a monk to come to someone's hotel room was not the way things were done.

I digress briefly to note my annoyance at the increasing use of cell phones in temples. In the past year, I have visited numerous temples only to find monks scrolling on their phones and polluting the soundscape with TikTok videos. Suffice it to say, there are a lot of monks with time on their hands who could do something genuinely monastic — like

help someone grieve. Particularly when I was not requiring anyone to talk. Just sit with me.

However, the facade — the image and the protection of that image — meant that these monks were seen as saintly beings, and it might be disrespectful to their image to actually ask them to come and be of service in a spiritual moment and a spiritual crisis. Better not to disturb the monks scrolling TikTok, or acknowledge the fact that getting addicted to TikTok is the exact opposite of renouncing attachment.

I believe the hotel thought it would be rude to the idea — not the reality, but the idea — of a monk sitting silently for days in meditation, to come and ask one to walk a hundred meters down the road and actually help someone be present for themselves. They couldn't face the affront to the idea of the monk and actually deal with an actual monk or an actual guest.

I also think that the idea of professionalism — which in the West amounts to the subjugation and sublimation of all personal feeling toward the goal of money and physical performance — could not handle the idea of actually being a human being.

In my travels around the world, I have noticed with incredulity and a certain amount of cynicism and disgust that the more wealthy, the more opulent, and the more educated the business, the more likely it is for staff to apologize for having feelings. To apologize for being a person with a personality. To apologize for talking or sharing anything about themselves. And to be horrified when a guest does the same.

As a result, it is far more effective, intelligent, and human to spend time in a rural village where nobody has learned to apologize for being alive, warm, emotional, truthful, and spontaneous.

I say this with some confidence because I had once been in a similar emotionally overwhelmed state. But this time I was not in a five-star hotel. I was in a shack with a tin roof. In a little village store where the average item cost fifty cents, children wandered in and out barefoot with their dogs to buy various items for their homes.

No one around me had a PhD, and so they had not been robbed of their humanity. The children behaved spontaneously, warmly, often smiled or hid shyly behind an older person.

The shop owner glanced at my face and understood immediately what my face was communicating. She put her hands on my head without speaking a word of English and gave me a five-minute massage while humming. Without asking for permission.

She was an exquisite human being who had never been to college or hotel school and had never learned what it means to be a professional. As a mother and an emotional human being herself, she understood the cycle of emotions, the cycle of grief, and what was needed. She took me in her arms and loved me.

And in five minutes, she gave me more than three hundred hotel staff at one of the best hotels on earth.

How is it, I wondered, that being a professional seems to mean being separated from one's humanity? And how is it that people who have not gone through that rigorous erasure of soul have it naturally — have it at birth, and it was never taken away from them?

By some miracle, if this woman were hired — though I'm sure she would be rejected by every five-star hotel for a number of reasons, not the least of which was that she didn't particularly care about her appearance — she would

probably be told that she couldn't touch guests, that this was unprofessional. And be shamed for the very thing that had given me more, in my most vulnerable moment, than all the five-star hotels of the world had ever given me.

She gave me a moment of solidarity, empathy, and kindness when I did not know how to give that to myself and could not find it anywhere on earth.

I want to pause for a moment on that sentence. Because when I found myself feeling seventy percent better in five minutes — because one human being had seen me and cared about me and with no thought of monetary gain had given me love — I reflected on the fact that, other than her dog, who also gave me love, I did not know anywhere on earth that I could go to experience the same feeling.

As a result, I showed up daily at this shack with barefoot kids, petted her dog, and often received a thirty-second to three-minute head massage without either of us being able to speak a word in each other's language. It was not sexual. And yet I felt immense gratitude that somewhere on earth, there were still human beings who were willing to see and willing to care because that's who they were.

As I watched the horrified faces of the five-star hotel staff — who couldn't see, who didn't want to see, who had to perform the ritual of asking how every guest was doing — I told them how I was doing. I told them that it would be wonderful if they could bring a monk over. And I said, for that matter, it doesn't have to be a monk. Any single human being around here, on the hotel staff or otherwise, who would sit with me for twenty minutes would help enormously.

The hotel apparently had a meeting to discuss the crisis — a meeting that might have taken twenty minutes and might have involved ten or more team members, which amounts to two hundred minutes of collective time.

Exotic whiskeys could be flown in from around the world, apparently. Exquisite seafood dishes could be fresh-caught and rushed on ice to the hotel, apparently. But a single human being, of any sex, of any gender, of any age — to sit with a hotel guest as a human being — was out of the question.

On some level, it felt so surreal it was laughable. What they were saying, in fact, was: we cannot produce a single

human being who is capable of transcending their role and being human, to actually be with another human being.

They were all very embarrassed about this. And they avoided looking at me and hurried away, as if I carried a disease.

While waiting for a human being to show up, a hotel maintenance technician came into my room furtively and locked the sliding glass door on my balcony so that I couldn't open it. I confirmed with the hotel staff — who apparently had had a meeting about this — that they were worried I would commit suicide.

I noted the irony and the absurdity. They were worried enough to have a meeting. They believed it was likely I would commit suicide. But the thought of a guest committing suicide — a guest who had one single request, to sit with another human being for twenty minutes, something a hotel could do for free — was not as important to the hotel as breaking a rule. The cult of professionalism was more important than potentially saving the life of a guest.

And so, rather than receiving any emotional support for the next forty-eight hours, I suffered the curse of being

shamed for telling the truth, for being a human being, and for being proud of it. I was not willing to lie and say that everything was fine, that the whole world was perfect. I was not willing to bury my personal feelings. And I was not willing to pretend that being a hotel guest and being a hotel team member — as defined in the hotel training manual — was more important than being human.

I would have held every single team member in that hotel if they had told me the truth. But they understood that they would probably get fired if they let their humanity emerge.

As an aside, I've often noticed that hotel staff are five times more interesting, lively, and emotional after work — when they think no customers are around — than when they are somberly and quietly doing their duties. They understood that their security and their reputation among the cult of professionals were at stake if they showed their humanity. And that's what it took to turn them from innocent children and natural human beings into sociopathic professionals living in terror of losing their jobs.

I understood that this was wrong. I avoided this hotel after this experience. Not because I thought there was anything unique about this hotel — I'm sure any other five-star hotel would have done the same. But because, for a while, looking at the hotel reminded me of the disgusting reality that at the top of Western culture, people were systematically trained to be less human, less honest, less spontaneous, less alive than they were when they were born. And they were bribed with large amounts of money for perfecting the ritual of dissociation from themselves. And were punished with shame and termination for breaking the cult code — a cult code I had gotten to know well in my own family, where the rule was always that whoever showed any emotion at all was humiliated for doing so.

These experiences point directly to deep flaws that permeate most of hospitality. And the flaw begins the moment a hotel team member is trained to separate from themselves and their families and create a mask of polite professionalism that has nothing to do with who they are — in order to get money to satisfy society's demand that one's value as a family member and in the world is

measured by one's wealth. Not one's kindness. Not one's emotional depth. Not one's presence.

I will close this section of my worst hotel experiences with an observation. At several of the lowest points in my life, I recognized that I would spend any amount of money to feel better. And that's what I wanted more than anything else: someone to take me in their arms. Someone to listen to me and not be interested in anything but the truth. Someone to see me and to actually care.

But it's not on the menu. I could scroll through a hundred thousand Amazon items, and there wasn't one thing that would give me that experience. I could travel anywhere in the world without any predictable way to create that experience.

That is very different from someone looking at you in a wordless space and being there for you. Sitting there with you and telling you that you are seen, heard, and welcome as a human being. And the understanding that someone gave you this gift because it's their nature to do so.

In short, what makes capitalism a cult — and what makes culture a cult — is the fact that, in many cases I've experienced, a capitalist will choose to make less money

rather than honor certain feelings and their own humanity. That a culture will willingly suffer to avoid changing its cult code. That a hotel would rather risk the suicide of a guest and the loss of all future business of a dead client than take twenty minutes to hold his hand.

That is the cult code. That is the antithesis of hospitality and of humanity. And it makes less money — because when the human being is murdered to make room for the professional and the cult code, people get sicker faster, burn out faster, take more drugs and alcohol, hate themselves more, and die sooner.

In short: in both of these experiences, my hotels would have made more money by being human. But they gave up the money to follow the code rather than their human instincts that they were born with.

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Now let's turn to a happier subject — my best hotel experiences.

Unfortunately, these are not as memorable because what makes an absolutely peak experience is, unfortunately, almost impossible to fit into the roles of a hotel. As a result,

my greatest experiences have always been with friends and lovers. There is no need for that to be the case. It's simply that, in the way professionalism is currently defined, almost everything that is truly exceptional is either illegal or just not done within the paradigm of professionalism.

However, these are some of the things that come to mind.

I recently flew to China for the first time in my life — my first firsthand experience of Chinese culture. I am not a fan of Chinese food, and I'm a vegetarian. But there were one or two Chinese restaurants in San Francisco that had the most amazing vegetarian dumplings and interesting sauces.

The food and beverage manager had spent some time in the US. He first agreed with me that corn, leek, and shiitake mushroom dumplings were absolutely delicious. He then commiserated with the fact that, unfortunately, none of the three restaurants in the hotel offered great vegetarian dumplings, and that there was meat in almost every single dish in the buffet. What he was doing here was rare. First, he was telling the truth — the whole truth. That he understood and liked the same kinds of dumplings that

I liked. Secondly, they were nowhere in the entire hotel. And thirdly, that as a result, his favorite place to eat was not in the hotel. It was a place nearby. So far, just well above average — truth over role.

Now comes the best part of the story. I could not read Chinese maps, could not get WeChat to work on my phone, and China had gone to great lengths to make sure Google Maps wouldn't work. When I asked him where his dumpling place was, he understood that the odds of me finding it were relatively low. And he offered, spontaneously: come, let's go for a walk — I'll take you there.

The food and beverage manager of a major hotel put his other duties aside to make sure that I would feel personally welcome and could eat good vegetarian food that wasn't available at his hotel. He didn't pull out a food app — of which there were some — and invite me to order. Instead, he walked with me. He talked with me. He had an interest in how I was experiencing China. And he walked me all of the way to his dumpling place, which I agreed I would never have found without his help. He then helped me place the order. And when the staff did not want to deviate from standard protocol — because they were

deeply entrenched in the impersonal mode of "this is what we do and this is how we do it, and we don't care about anything other than that" — he talked with them politely for about five minutes until they agreed to give me the kinds of dumplings that I liked. He even helped me pay for them before saying he had to get back to his duties.

This experience stands out for me because he put humanity ahead of role, ahead of money. He understood what it was like to be in a strange place. And he was more interested in what I liked and my experience than he was in conformity and roles. I still feel a sense of wonder, a sense of joy, a sense of peace — and slight awe — that someone in China, in fact, one of the first Chinese people I met in China, put understanding and responding to me ahead of anything else.

In short, I felt more like a human being in China than I did in most of the US. And this experience sticks with me today. It's the first thing that comes to mind when I think of peak experiences.

And this is even more significant when I consider the fact that his hotel had average architecture. His buffet was average food. The hotel staff's uniform was average. The

walk to the dumpling shop was average. And even the shop's dumplings were not even half as good as the dumplings I had tasted at my favorite Chinese restaurant in the United States.

And yet, this is the first experience that comes to mind when I think of the best experiences I've had in hotels. This is a very significant piece of evidence. It suggests that the need and the importance of seeing and being seen as a human being is so great that one can have peak experiences in a mud hut or an average hotel that are completely unavailable in top-tier hotels in places like Dubai — where the architecture is ten times more stunning, where the hotel staff may be more beautiful, and the menu more exotic, but where I never had this kind of authentic experience of being treated like a human being first.

My next experience is at the same hotel. I had mentioned that the buffet was incredibly limited for vegetarians, and so ordering à la carte made sense. I was having various troubles with translation and feeling a bit helpless, as most of my US apps didn't work for one reason or another, and even the internet was difficult to get sometimes. And when I feel helpless, frustrated, and isolated, I start to become tired, irritable, and impatient.

But this hostess, similar to the food and beverage manager, was making an effort to attune. She was warm and present and seemed to make it her personal interest to see that I got what I needed. I felt like I had an ally. And I found it interesting that she was not particularly senior in the hotel, and she was much younger than me. But as I complained about each of the things I was not happy about, she listened and didn't take it personally.

And when I told her I was tired of waiting around for everything and to hurry up, she literally started running to go find the chef in the kitchen — running in a kind of cute and playful way, to let me know that she was aware that I was annoyed at waiting so long. She basically became my advocate. Why should he pay so much for a hotel buffet that had only ten percent of its offerings for vegetarians? She was going to add some à la carte dishes to the buffet for the same price. Why was this happening? Why was that happening? And because she was well-liked among the team members, they all complied, and I had excellent service from that point. They actually remembered what I liked. She was always warm and smiley. She also enjoyed talking with me. And it was equally fun to see her and her

boyfriend, who also helped me, and to learn about their budding romance.

The next experience is also at this same Chinese hotel. The guest director wanted to know how I was enjoying the hotel. She invited me into the VIP area of another Chinese restaurant and arranged for me to have various forms of Chinese tea as a courtesy. She also tasted and passed me one of the nicest desserts on the menu, at her expense. She sat with me, talked with me, listened attentively, and had dinner with me. And when one of the junior bartenders was making a fuss at the idea of serving Grand Marnier warm so that I could enjoy the aroma, this woman called over another team member and discussed how to make warm Grand Marnier happen.

I found myself utterly delighted with the present eye contact and interest that this woman was giving me. I'm sure some of this has to do with Chinese culture, and some of it has to do with these individual people. But there it is. It comes to mind as one of the best experiences I've had anywhere in the world, in any hotel. Partly because it's recent. But mostly because I want to highlight the fact that I had a negative predisposition toward China due to US propaganda and stereotyping. The hotel was mediocre in

many ways. And yet three team members — of all ages, a man and two women — made me feel at home, seen, cared about, and welcome in a way that I can't think of feeling anywhere else at any other time. And they did it spontaneously, at almost zero expense to the hotel.

In other words, I can think of many hotels that spent ten times the amount of money this hotel spent on art, décor, construction, views, and various amenities — that did not leave me feeling this way. In fact, at the Atlantis hotel, which I'd experienced just before — a six-hundred-dollar-a-night hotel in Dubai — I had the exact opposite experience. Irritation. Invisibility. Incredulity at the stupidity of the protocols. And I didn't meet a single present person.

This hotel had spent ten times less money. Probably twenty times less. And yet it stands out because of the quality of its presence and its people. And perhaps because of a culture of hospitality in its own unique way.

I'm looking forward to going back to this hotel. Not because I like the weather in China. Not because I like the food in China. Not because I liked the architecture of this hotel. I'm looking forward to going back to see three

individuals who treated me like a human being and a friend. And so I will spend a thousand dollars in logistics and another thousand in hotel costs just to see my friends again. Because I know, from the way they responded to me, that they see me as a human being, that they're happy to see me.

And in another odd twist, I feel more from these three people than I feel from many of my so-called friends that I've known much longer, who have less interest in seeing and understanding me than these relatively new strangers in China.

I believe this highlights a new frontier in true hospitality. I also believe that there are many people whose nature is to do what these three did — who would do it naturally if it wasn't beaten out of them.

I also know that how they treated me wasn't personal in the sense that they would only treat me this way. When you find people who truly enjoy bringing happiness to others, who truly enjoy seeing and being seen, who truly enjoy connecting — they do it to everyone. It's not about the other person. It's about who they are.

And this metric is the single most important metric that I know — in hospitality, in a 10x hotel, in any relationship.

And it is a metric that, in current models, is completely invisible. In fact, it is punished. In many establishments, talking too long with a guest, being emotional, telling the truth, and not sticking to one's job description — these would be seen as liabilities. Rather than the truth: that this is the behavior that would see a well-seasoned traveler fly all the way back to a dreary hotel, just to see his friends.

About the Author

Dane Rose

Dane Rose has been designing environments and human experiences for more than thirty-three years. As a business owner for that entire period, he developed a rare fluency in the relationship between people and the spaces they inhabit. His explorations in design have spanned painting, sculpture, and more than twenty books.

As a long-term global traveler with a passion for design, Dane has developed a precise understanding of what great hospitality is capable of becoming.

The 10X Hotel is a distillation of that lifelong inquiry — and an invitation to build something the world has never quite seen before.